

SUPERHUMAN ROCK PAPER SCISSORS

Game Design Document

Version 1.0

A browser-based competitive RPS game set in 2050, where superhuman abilities, skill trees, and powerups collide

Status: Active Development — skill point economy locked; portrait system in progress

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Version Control

Note: Version numbers in this table refer to design document revisions. Game release version milestones (v0.1 MVP through v1.0) are a separate, independent numbering scheme defined in Section 18.

Version	Date	Summary
0.1	2026-04-22	Initial design document. Core systems defined: account/character, season/tournament structure, round loop, skill tree framework, powerup system, NPC strategy schema, ELO/ranking, Hall of Fame, UI/UX specs, coach character, and MVP roadmap.
0.2	2026-04-23	Game renamed to Superhuman Rock Paper Scissors. INSTINCT tree renamed to MIND. SNES/16-bit retro visual style. Intro narration screen. Jessie reframed as competitive advantage. 100 total players. NPC powerup behavior system. Throw distribution stats. Active skill system with phase affinity. Trust My Luck reframed as standard active skill. Signature mechanics framework. NPC tournament level attribute. Hierarchical dot notation naming. Skill tree structure redesigned with typed node roles. Powerup root and synergy effects finalized.
0.3	2026-04-24	Complete skill tree node definitions for all three trees. Round flow revised. Round history panel UI added. Counter interactions fully specified. Coding gotchas documented. TBD list captured. Skill tree diagrams added as appendix.
0.4	2026-04-24	Synergy passive components finalized. Complete powerup catalog: 37 powerups across 4 trees, 3 tiers. Scope/activation/icon framework. Jessie Jones integration. Key numerics locked. Appendix B: session context preserved.
0.5	2026-04-25	MVP Scope & Version Roadmap incorporated. Version numbering clarification added. NPC count normalized to 99 NPCs + 1 player = 100 total. purist strategy refactored to puristRock/puristPaper/puristScissors/puristRandom. signatureMechanic replaced with greeting field. powerupTriggers replaced with powerupStrategy enum. powerupInventory field added. NPC roster begun: T1 (10) and T2 (15) complete.
0.6	2026-04-25	Season & Tournament Structure incorporated as Section 2 (all subsequent sections renumbered). Match structure table added. T3 (20),

Version	Date	Summary
		T4 (25), and T5 (29) NPC batches complete — full 99 NPC roster now defined in npc_roster.json.
0.7	2026-04-25	Gap-recovery pass: restored Core Design Pillars, Technology Stack, Visual Style, Account & Character System, Jessie's Competitive Advantage, Skill Resolution Hierarchy, Information Reliability, Tree Structure overview, Node Naming Convention, Node Type Reference, Active Skill Schema, Skill Classification System, Powerup Root + Synergy summary table, Mid-season add-only respec rule, Powerup Tiers, Slots & Starting Loadout, Powerup Drop System, Upgrade Chance baseline, Powerup Scope, Active Powerup UI, Powerup Thematic Linking, Throw Distribution Statistics, Tournament Level Distribution + Local NPCs Everywhere, ELO & Global Ranking, Hall of Fame, Trophy & Achievement, UI/UX Specifications, Coach Jessie character spec + Milestone Dialogue, Terminology Appendix. MVP Scope updates: SNES visual style and intro narration restored to v0.2 milestone; active skill system note restored to v0.3 milestone. Sections renumbered. Appendix B expanded with gap-recovery context and superseded mechanics reference.
0.7	2026-04-26	NPC behavioral equivalents for all MIND tree player-only skills locked (Option A — passive accuracy model). MIND.1.1.1.1 renamed from Total Recall to Neural Scan 2.0; effect updated: replaces Neural Scan, same 90% accurate on-demand read, cooldown reduced from 5 matches to 3 matches. Naming collision between MIND.1.1.1.1 and MIND.1.2.1.1 resolved. Section 10.7 fully populated: NPR (+10% accuracy override), Neural Scan (5-match spike), Neural Scan 2.0 (3-match spike), Adv. NPR (+15% override), Desperate Clarity (+20% boost after 2 consecutive losses), Mental Mysticism (15% tie-to-win after first read-influenced win), Uncanny Mind (identical to player version), Blank Slate (~5% read accuracy on NPC), Memory Wipe (+1 round to all player cooldowns currently counting down), Total Recall (+2 rounds to all player cooldowns currently counting down), Clean Slate (33% cooldown refresh on Memory Wipe/Total Recall activation), The Cooler (50% TML/ATML block, upgrades to 75% with Freezer), Not Today! (95% TML/ATML block, every 3 rounds), The Freezer (upgrades Cooler 50%→75%), IGaH (50% accuracy spike every 3 rounds, not subject to Phantom Memory/Mind Shield/Blank Slate). Section 10.7 fully complete — no remaining TBDs.
0.8	2026-04-26	Flavor text system complete: full verb phrase and counter descriptor table added to Section 5.4.1. Skill classification tags (TBD #2) reclassified as implementation concern — Section 16.12 coding note added. Consolation bonus system fully locked (Section 4.6): fixed skill point awards by tournament level (T1: 25 pts through T5: 5 pts), Jessie dialogue locked for all five tiers, choose-from-3 mechanic removed. All consolation references updated for consistency across Sections 4.2, 4.4, 4.5, 14.6, 18.3. TBD #9 closed. B.12 Next Session Agenda updated.
0.9	2026-04-26	Skill point economy locked and simplified. Season 1 starting points (15 pts) clarified as one-time only — not awarded every season. All references updated: Sections 4.2, 4.3, 4.4, 10.2, 10.6. TBD #6 closed. NPC portrait system complete: all 99 NPCs assigned portraitId from 50-portrait pool (25 male, 25 female). Format: male_N / female_N. Cultural tone matched to NPC name origin. No same-portrait conflicts within any

Version	Date	Summary
		tournament tier. Sections 2.2, 3.3, 10.2 updated to reflect direct-assignment model. TBD #8 closed. B.10 and B.12 updated.
0.95	2026-04-26	localStorage schema defined and documented (all 9 key buckets, NPC initialisation algorithm, season-end simulation write order). Section 8.3.1 added: Season Starting Loadout — all tree combinations fully specified, MYSTIC.1 conflict resolved (drop modifier only, never affects starting loadout), baseline state eliminated by new mandate. Minimum spend mandate added: player must purchase at least one node before starting any season or completing off-season respec — Lock In button gated on this condition. Sections 4.2, 4.7, 14.4 updated. Section 16.13 (coding note) added. NPC starting budget by tier locked: T1 5 pts, T2 15 pts, T3 35 pts, T4 55 pts, T5 75 pts — defined as named constant NPC_STARTING_BUDGET_BY_TIER. NPC skill point spending confirmed as random-from-legal-nodes. NPC vs NPC simulation confirmed as ELO-probability only. NPC skill points spent once at season end only.
1.0	2026-04-27	Coach Jessie complete dialogue set locked. Tutorial beats T-01 through T-14 fully specified (T-10 retired, T-11 merged into T-08). Milestone beats M-01 through M-12 fully specified. Sections 15.4 and 15.5 added. Section 12.3 updated: HOF induction is a 4-box sequence. Section 2.2 corrected: player portrait pool is 50 (not 20). Section 15.3 milestone table updated from placeholder to full M-01–M-12 reference. Section 16.14 added (Jessie one-shot gate gotcha). localStorage schema v1.0: jessieOneShots and jessieSeasonCheckInHistory added to _trophies. TBD #14 closed. CLAUDE.md, DECISIONS.md, TODO.md updated to v1.0.

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1. Game Overview

1.1 Concept

Superhuman Rock Paper Scissors (SRPS) is a browser-based single-player strategy game set in 2050. Players choose skill trees that define their competitive identity, earn powerups, and face a living ecosystem of 99 NPC competitors across a 10-season career arc. Visual style: SNES/16-bit retro pixel art throughout.

1.2 The Three Trees

MIND — Deduce it	MYSTIC — Bend it	FORTUNE — Trust it
Cold analytical deduction. Superhuman pattern recognition, tell-reading, strategy decryption. Counters FORTUNE. Synergizes with MYSTIC.	Supernatural reality alteration. Tie conversion, psychic deflection, opponent control. Counters MIND. Synergizes with FORTUNE.	Cosmic luck and probability surrender. Trust My Luck, powerup avalanches, loss-triggered compensation. Counters MYSTIC. Synergizes with MIND.

1.3 Intro Narration (approved text)

The year is 2050. Humanity solved a lot of problems. Climate change. Disease. The eternal debate over whether a hot dog is a sandwich. But one obsession consumed us above all others. When scientists discovered that biotech implants could unlock superhuman abilities — microscopic reaction times, preternatural pattern recognition, the uncanny sense of what another person was about to do — the world's governments, corporations, and militaries immediately recognized the implications. They used this technology exclusively to get better at Rock Paper Scissors. By 2042, the UN had formally adopted RPS as the universal framework for resolving all disputes. Elections. Trade wars. Territorial boundaries. The World Champion held more informal power than any head of state. Children dressed as them for Halloween. You have spent your whole life dreaming of that title. Today, in a small gymnasium that smells faintly of linoleum and ambition, your journey begins.

Intro screen: text revealed at reading pace (~50 words/minute for dramatic effect). SNES-style pixel font, dark background, subtle scanline effect. Skip button available. Approximately 45–60 seconds at full pace.

1.4 Core Design Pillars

- Strategic identity through tree lock-in — your two trees define who you are as a competitor. Once committed, players are locked in for the playthrough, encouraging repeated runs to explore other combinations.
- Meaningful randomness — RPS is never fully solved, keeping every round tense regardless of skill level.
- Living world — 99 NPC competitors with real ELO ratings, skill trees, and season trajectories make the rankings feel real.
- Aspirational progression — bottom-tier (Level 4) tree nodes should feel legendary; reaching them across 10 seasons is an achievement.
- Replayability — full off-season respects, consolation bonuses, and three distinct tree identities reward repeated playthroughs.
- Retro charm — SNES/16-bit aesthetic throughout; pixel art portraits, chunky UI panels, retro animations.

1.5 Technology Stack

Platform: Browser-based, cross-platform (PC, iOS, Android). No installation required.

Component	Technology	Rationale
Core Engine	Vanilla HTML5 + Canvas + JavaScript	Zero dependencies, runs in any browser, no build step, excellent Claude Code support

Component	Technology	Rationale
Styling	CSS3 with optional Tailwind CDN for UI	Lightweight, no install required
Data Persistence	Browser localStorage	Simple, no backend required for v0.1–v0.3; cross-device migration planned for v1.0
Hosting	Static file hosting (GitHub Pages / Netlify)	Free tier sufficient; no server required
Portraits & Sprites	SVG/Canvas pixel art	Programmatic pixel art — palette-swappable, no asset licenses needed
Audio	None (v1.0)	Deferred; 8-bit chiptune style when added

v1.0 Stretch Goal: Migrate from localStorage to a server-based backend (Node.js + database) for true cross-device account persistence. Schema should be designed from day one to make this migration clean.

2. Visual Style — SNES / 16-bit Retro

2.1 Aesthetic Direction

The entire game uses a SNES/early 16-bit era aesthetic. This is not a superficial filter — it defines every visual element from UI chrome to character portraits to animations. The style should feel like a polished SNES RPG/sports game hybrid: rich enough to be expressive, pixelated enough to be unmistakably retro.

Element	Style Guidance
Typography	Pixel fonts throughout. Menu text in chunky bitmap font. Flavor text in slightly smaller pixel font.
Color Palette	Rich but limited palette per screen, consistent with SNES hardware feel. Bold primaries, strong contrast.
UI Panels	Chunky bordered panels with SNES-style drop shadows. Think Final Fantasy VI menu boxes.
Backgrounds	Pixel art environments. Tournament venues rendered as pixel art backdrops.
Animations	Sprite-based. Countdown animation, throw reveal, win/loss celebration all use pixel animation frames.
Screen Transitions	Classic wipe / iris / checkerboard transitions between screens.
Intro Screen	Dark background, scanline effect, text revealed in pixel font with classic RPG text-crawl pacing.
Coach Jessie	Pixel art character portrait in RPG dialog box — think Chrono Trigger NPC style.

Element	Style Guidance
Portraits	All player and NPC portraits are pixel art sprites. 48×48 or 64×64 base size, scaled up.
Trophies	Pixel art trophy icons, animated sparkle on earn.
Skill Tree	Retro RPG skill menu aesthetic — node graph with pixel art connector lines.
Powerup Icons	Pixel art icons, ~24×24px base. Glow effect by tier (Basic: white, Advanced: blue, Legendary: gold).

2.2 Portrait Style

- Player portraits: 50 distinct pixel art options (25 male, 25 female), 48×48 or 64×64 base resolution, scaled up 2–3x. Any portrait may be chosen regardless of gender.
- NPC portraits: 50 distinct pixel art portraits (25 male, 25 female). Direct assignment — no palette swaps required. Cultural tone matched to NPC name origin.
- Coach Jessie: unique pixel art portrait, female, Hall of Fame aura — distinct from player/NPC pool.
- All portraits framed in SNES-style portrait boxes during match screen.
- Implementation: SVG/Canvas-based for palette swap support. Placeholder set for v0.1, final pixel art for v1.0.

3. Account & Character System

3.1 Account

Players create a local account with a username and password stored in localStorage (hashed). Each account supports 1 to 3 characters. The login screen is the entry point of the game.

Field	Details
Username	Unique identifier, chosen at account creation.
Password	Stored as a hash in localStorage.
Characters	1 to 3 per account, each independently tracked.
Persistence	localStorage — device-specific until v1.0 backend migration (stretch goal).

3.2 Character

Each character is an independent career with its own name, portrait, skill tree state, ELO rating, season history, and trophy case.

Field	Details
Name	Player-defined at character creation.

Field	Details
Portrait	Chosen from the full pool of 50 pixel art portraits (25 male, 25 female) via a scrollable selection screen at character creation. Any portrait may be chosen regardless of gender. Format: male_N or female_N.
Primary Tree	Chosen Season 1 before first tournament; locked for the playthrough.
Secondary Tree	Chosen Season 2 before first tournament; locked for the playthrough. Must differ from primary.
Skill Points	Accumulated across the season; fully refunded and reallocatable each off-season.
ELO Rating	Starts at baseline; updated after each tournament.
Season	Current season number (1–10).
Trophy Case	Record of all tournament trophies earned across the career.
Throw Stats	Lifetime R/P/S distribution. See Section 9 for tracking scopes.
Career Stats	Win/loss record, tournament finishes, peak ELO, Hall of Fame status.

3.3 Player & NPC Portraits

Player portraits: the full pool of 50 pixel art portraits (25 male, 25 female) is available at character creation. The player scrolls through all 50 options and selects one. Any portrait may be chosen regardless of the character's name or gender. Each portrait is unique — no palette swaps. Character creation flow: enter name → scroll and select portrait → proceed.

NPC portraits: 50 distinct pixel art portraits (25 male, 25 female). Direct assignment — no palette swaps needed. Cultural tone matched to NPC name origin. All 99 NPCs assigned in v0.9; portraitId format is male_N or female_N (N = 1–25).

Portrait assets are final pixel art (50 portraits: 25 male, 25 female). Placeholder set ships in v0.1; final pixel art pass for v1.0. Jessie has 8 expression variants (default, angry, determined, facepalm, fistpump, sad, whisper, worried).

4. Season & Tournament Structure

4.1 Season Overview

A season consists of up to 5 sequential tournaments of increasing size and prestige. The player advances by reaching the finals (top 2) of each tournament. Failing to reach the finals ends the season. Winning the World Championship also ends the season. After the season ends, the player enters the off-season phase.

Tournament	Name	Rounds	Players	Requirement to Advance
T1	Local Championship	2	4	Reach the Final (win 1 match)
T2	Regional Championship	3	8	Reach the Final (win 2 matches)

Tournament	Name	Rounds	Players	Requirement to Advance
T3	National Championship	4	16	Reach the Final (win 3 matches)
T4	Continental Championship	5	32	Reach the Final (win 4 matches)
T5	World Championship	6	64	Win the Championship (win all 6 matches)

Advancement Rule: Both finalists (winner AND runner-up) are invited to the next tournament. A player who loses in any round before the final has their season ended immediately.

4.2 Season Flow

Pre-Season: Player selects primary tree (Season 1) or secondary tree (Season 2). Allocates starting skill points (Season 1 only — 15 pts from Jessie's initial training). At least one node must be purchased before the season can begin — the Lock In button on the skill tree screen is disabled until this condition is met. Reviews powerup loadout.

During Season: Compete in tournaments sequentially. After each tournament win or runner-up finish, skill points are awarded and can be immediately allocated. Powerups accumulate and are consumed during matches.

Season End (Loss): Post-loss summary screen with stats. Consolation bonus awarded by Jessie (skill points scaled to how early the season ended). Off-season respec. Then new season begins.

Season End (Championship Win): Celebration screen with stats. Off-season respec. Then new season begins.

4.3 Skill Point Awards

Tournament	Winner	Runner-Up (Finalist)
T1 Local	10 pts	5 pts
T2 Regional	15 pts	7 pts
T3 National	20 pts	10 pts
T4 Continental	25 pts	12 pts
T5 World Championship	30 pts	15 pts

Starting points Season 1 only: 15 points (allocated before Tournament 1, framed as Jessie's initial pre-season training).

Perfect season total (all wins): $15 + 10 + 15 + 20 + 25 + 30 = 115$ points in Season 1, then 100 points per subsequent season.

Estimated 10-season perfect run total: approximately 1,015 points before bonuses.

Economy Design Goal: A focused 10-season run should yield approximately 4–5 level-4 (bottom) skill tree nodes. Reaching every bottom node in both trees should be virtually impossible. This is intentional — it drives replayability and makes each bottom node feel aspirational.

4.4 Jessie's Competitive Advantage

Coach Jessie Jones provides the player with two advantages that no NPC receives — grounding the mechanical advantages in the game's narrative:

- Starting 15 skill points in Season 1 only — Jessie's initial pre-season training gives the player a one-time head start NPCs never get.
- Consolation bonus — Jessie's off-season coaching turns a losing season into a learning opportunity. She awards the player bonus skill points (scaled by how early the season ended) before the off-season respec. NPCs never receive this bonus.

Player advantage extends beyond Jessie: one-time 15-point Season 1 start and full off-season respec capability. NPCs receive neither.

4.5 Off-Season

The off-season occurs after every season ends (win or loss). During the off-season:

- All spent skill points are fully refunded.
- Player may completely reallocate points within their two chosen trees.
- Powerups are cleared — the player starts fresh each season.
- Player receives a starting powerup loadout based on their tree choices.
- If Season ended in a loss (non-finalist, non-championship): Jessie delivers consolation bonus skill points before respec. Amount scales by tournament reached (see Section 4.6).
- NPCs do NOT receive off-season respecs — their trees grow by addition only.

4.6 Consolation Bonus

When a season ends with the player eliminated before reaching the finals of any tournament, Jessie appears in her RPG dialog box and delivers a pep talk followed by a fixed skill point award. The award is determined by which tournament the player was knocked out of. Runner-up finishes (finalists who lost) are not eligible — they already receive skill points via Section 4.3 and advance to the next tournament. Champions receive no consolation bonus. NPCs never receive consolation bonuses.

The bonus is awarded before the off-season respec. Skill points from the consolation bonus are added to the player's starting pool for the next season alongside the standard 15 starting points.

Knocked Out In	Bonus Points	Rationale
T1 Local Championship	25 pts	Entire off-season available. Maximum training time with Jessie.
T2 Regional Championship	20 pts	Most of the off-season remaining. Significant training time.
T3 National Championship	15 pts	Good stretch of off-season time. Focused sessions together.
T4 Continental Championship	10 pts	Limited off-season. A few hard sessions squeezed in.
T5 World Championship	5 pts	Almost no off-season. A handful of sessions before it starts again.

Trigger: Player eliminated before reaching the finals of any tournament (not runner-up, not champion). Delivered by Jessie in her RPG dialog box before the off-season respec screen. Points added to next season's starting pool on top of the standard 15 starting points.

Jessie's Consolation Dialogue (locked)

Tournament	Jessie's Dialogue (pep talk + award sentence)
T1 Local (25 pts)	"Hey. That one stings, I know. But you know what? We've got the whole off-season. I'm talking early mornings, late nights, the works. By the time we're done, you're going to be a completely different competitor. Take these points — you earned every one of them." / "Your intensive off-season training yielded 25 new skill points to spend before next season!"
T2 Regional (20 pts)	"Regional's a tough draw. But honestly? This is exactly the kind of loss that makes champions. We've got time to fix what went wrong. I've already got a training plan in my head. These points are from us putting in the work together." / "Your dedicated off-season work earned you 20 new skill points to spend before next season!"
T3 National (15 pts)	"You made it to Nationals. That's real. And now we know exactly what we need to sharpen. We'll use this off-season well — I promise you that. Here's what our sessions together earned you." / "Your focused off-season sessions earned you 15 new skill points to spend before next season!"
T4 Continental (10 pts)	"Continental. You were right there. The gap between you and the top is smaller than you think — I've seen it up close. We don't have a lot of off-season left, but we're going to make every session count. These points are from the work we squeezed in." / "Your off-season work together earned you 10 new skill points to spend before next season!"
T5 World (5 pts)	"You made the World Championship. Let that land for a second. The off-season is short — almost no time at all before it starts again — but we found a few sessions together, and I want you to have what we worked on. You're ready." / "Those sessions together earned you 5 new skill points to spend before next season!"

4.7 Tree Selection Rules

Season	Rule
Season 1	Choose one tree only. Spend starting 15 points within that tree only. At least one node must be purchased before Tournament 1 begins.
Season 2+	Choose a second tree (permanent for this playthrough). Both trees now available.
All Seasons	Third tree is permanently locked out and hidden from the UI.
Off-Season	Full respec allowed within the two chosen trees only. Tree choices cannot change. At least one node must be purchased before the respec can be locked in and the new season can begin.
Minimum Spend (All Seasons)	The player must purchase at least one node before any season begins (pre-season) or before any off-season respec is locked in. The Lock In button is disabled until this condition is met. This ensures the starting powerup loadout is never in an undefined state — every season starts with at least the root node purchased and its loadout seeded. The root node (L1, 5 pts) is always the cheapest legal node and will always be affordable given the player's point balance.

5. Round Flow

5.1 Match Structure

Match Type	Format	Clinch Condition
Regular Match	Best of 5 rounds	First to win 3 rounds
Finals Match	Best of 7 rounds	First to win 4 rounds

Ties (draws) in a round are replayed. Certain skills and powerups allow a player to convert a tie into a win.

5.2 Phase Structure

Phase	Name	Description
1	Throw Selection	Player picks R/P/S via large hand-symbol buttons. Powerups may be activated here. One active skill may be triggered here (uses the round's single active skill slot).
2	Gut Check	Skill information displays — reads, warnings, detections, false reads. Powerups may also be activated here. One active skill may be triggered here (if not already used in Phase 1). Certain skills/powerups grant ability to change throw — otherwise player reviews and hits Ready.
3	Countdown	3-2-1 pixel animation countdown.
4	Resolution	Both throws revealed. Round winner determined. Score updated. Tie triggers replay from Phase 1 (unless immune tie from Refuse to Lose).

One Active Skill Per Round: A player may trigger at most one active skill per round total across both phases. This is the primary balancing mechanism for powerful active skills.

Throw Change Gating: By default the player cannot change their blind selection during Gut Check. Only specific skills or powerups explicitly grant the ability to change the throw.

5.3 Round History Panel

Positioned on the right edge of the match screen — narrow column ~80px wide. Each row: round number (dim) | player icon | result indicator | NPC icon. Winner's icon: subtle gold pixel border highlight. Loser's icon: slightly dimmed. Ties: neutral pixel glyph between icons, both at normal brightness. Newest round at top — most recent history always visible without scrolling. Pixel art R/P/S hand symbols at ~24×24px. At ~34px per row, best-of-7 fits without scrolling.

5.4 Skill Information Phase — Message Types

Message Type	Example	Source
Strategy Read	"Opponent appears to be using a Counter strategy. 90% confidence"	NPR / Neural Scan / IGaH
False Strategy Read	"Opponent appears to be using a Cyclor strategy" (incorrect)	Phantom Memory / NPR false result
Tie Conversion Notice	"[Name] tried to Tweak Reality but [Name2] was Oblivious"	Counter skill flavor text
Skill Detection	"Opponent is attempting to influence you"	Counter-skill detection
Skill Nullification	"Opponent's influence has been blocked"	Defensive skill
Skill Backfire	"[Name] tried to [Skill] but it backfired"	Reverse Card / Bamboozle
Fizzle	(silent — no message shown)	IGaH failure, Lucky Charm no-tie fizzle

Flavor Text System: All counter interactions surface a message using the template: "[Attacker Name] tried to [Verb Phrase] but [Defender Name] was [Counter Descriptor]". Skill identification messages (detecting a skill is in use) are always truthful. Deception operates one level below — false reads look identical to correct ones, with no system-level tell. See Section 5.4.1 for the complete verb phrase and message table.

Information Reliability: Skill identification messages (detecting that an opponent is using a skill) are always truthful — this prevents the system from becoming unresolvable. Deception operates one level below meta-awareness. Confidence percentages from multiple read skills cap at 95% — never certainty.

5.4.1 Flavor Text Reference

All flavor text messages are generated from the template: "[Attacker Name] tried to [Verb Phrase] but [Defender Name] was [Counter Descriptor]". The verb phrase is fixed per attacking skill. The counter descriptor is fixed per counter skill. Implementation generates the full string at runtime by substituting player and NPC names.

Verb Phrases (per attacking skill)

Attacking Skill	Verb Phrase ("tried to ___")	Notes
NPR (Neural Pattern Recognition)	read your strategy	Passive; fires silently unless blocked or false-read planted.
Neural Scan / Neural Scan 2.0	scan your mind	Active; same verb for both skills (shared UI button).
IGaH (I've Got a Hunch)	play a hunch	Not subject to Mind Shield/Fortress or Phantom Memory — message only appears on IGaH success, never on block.

TML / ATML	trust their luck	Shared verb for both TML and ATML (same button/cooldown).
Tweak Reality / Alter Reality (passive)	tweak reality	Passive — fires on natural tie. Alter Reality uses same verb as it replaces Tweak Reality.
Force Your Hand / Twist Your Arm	force the outcome	Active; shared verb. Twist Your Arm replaces Force Your Hand entirely.

Counter Descriptors (per counter skill)

Counter Skill	Counter Descriptor ("was ____")	Notes
Mind Shield / Mind Fortress	Shielded	Both skills share one descriptor; Mind Fortress is the upgrade, not a separate skill for flavor purposes.
Phantom Memory	a Phantom	Fires after shield check passes. Message shown alongside the (false) read result. No "blocked" message — the deception is silent.
The Cooler / The Freezer	Ice Cold	The Freezer is an upgrade to The Cooler — both use this descriptor. Only fires when block succeeds (probabilistic).
Not Today!	Not Having It	Active; takes precedence over Cooler/Freezer. Distinct descriptor from The Cooler family to reflect the more decisive block.
Oblivious / Totes Oblivious	Oblivious	Totes Oblivious is the upgrade — same descriptor. The skill name IS the personality state, so it works as both noun and adjective in the sentence.
Lucky Charm	Lucky	Fires after Oblivious fails. Reversal message replaces the tie-conversion notice — the tie-alter is overwritten, not just blocked.

Example Generated Messages

Scenario	Generated Message
Player uses Neural Scan; NPC has Mind Shield (blocks)	"Alex tried to scan your mind but Vera Ashmore was Shielded"
NPC uses TML; player has Not Today! (blocks)	"Benny Kowalski tried to trust their luck but Alex was Not Having It"
NPC uses Tweak Reality (tie); player has Oblivious (blocks)	"Vera Ashmore tried to tweak reality but Alex was Oblivious"
NPC uses Force Your Hand; Oblivious fails; player's Lucky Charm reverses it	"Reginald Osei tried to force the outcome but Alex was Lucky"

5.5 Skill Resolution Hierarchy

When multiple skills conflict in a round, resolution follows this priority order:

1. Counter skills resolve first — nullify incoming skill effects before they fire.
2. Legendary powerups override everything except counters.
3. Active skills resolve next — higher tree level wins (Level 4 beats Level 2).
4. Passive skills apply last as modifiers.
5. Ties in precedence — defender wins (reinforcing the "defense is riskier but stronger" philosophy).

Stacking rules:

- Confidence percentages from multiple read skills cap at 95% (never certainty).
- Luck-based percentage bonuses stack additively.
- Duration effects from the same category do not stack — highest value wins.

This general hierarchy governs cases not covered by the specific Resolution Order matrix in Section 7.1. When the matrix specifies an order, that takes precedence; otherwise apply this hierarchy.

6. Skill Tree System

6.1 Tree Structure

Each tree contains 15 nodes arranged across 4 levels. All trees share the same structural template:

Level	Node Count	Cost per Node	Node Types
Level 1 (Root)	1	5 pts	Powerup system introduction — grants powerup capacity, loadout, drop rate, or quality bonuses.
Level 2	2	10 pts	Offense branch and Defense branch split.
Level 3	4	15 pts	Offense sub-branch (1 active + 1 synergy) and Defense sub-branch (1 active + 1 soft counter).
Level 4 (Bottom)	8	20 pts	Aspirational — powerful, specialized, largely unreachable in a single playthrough.

Tree structure schematic:

L1: [Root — Powerup Node]

L2: [Offense] [Defense]

L3: [Active Off] [Synergy] [Active Def] [Soft Counter]

L4: [Pwr Active][Pwr Pass] [Synergy A][Synergy P] [Pwr Active][Pwr Pass] [Hard Cntr A][Hard Cntr P]

Prerequisite Rule: Each node requires its parent node to be purchased before it can be unlocked. Players cannot skip levels.

6.2 Node Naming Convention

All nodes use hierarchical dot notation. X = tree name (MIND / MYSTIC / FORTUNE):

X.1	Level 1 — Root (Powerup node)
X.1.1	Level 2 — Passive Offense
X.1.2	Level 2 — Passive Defense
X.1.1.1	Level 3 — Active Offense
X.1.1.2	Level 3 — Passive Synergy (with Y tree)
X.1.2.1	Level 3 — Active Defense
X.1.2.2	Level 3 — Passive Soft Counter (vs Z tree)
X.1.1.1.1	Level 4 — Powerful Active Offense
X.1.1.1.2	Level 4 — Powerful Passive Offense
X.1.1.2.1	Level 4 — Synergy Active (bonus if Y has L2+)
X.1.1.2.2	Level 4 — Synergy Passive (bonus if Y has L2+)
X.1.2.1.1	Level 4 — Powerful Active Defense
X.1.2.1.2	Level 4 — Powerful Passive Defense
X.1.2.2.1	Level 4 — Hard Counter Active (vs Z tree)
X.1.2.2.2	Level 4 — Hard Counter Passive (vs Z tree)

Note: FORTUNE intentionally reverses Active/Passive at L2 and L3 in its offense branch — see FORTUNE tree table for detail.

6.3 Node Type Reference

Position	Type	Level	Cost	Description
X.1	Powerup Root	L1	5 pts	Introduces powerup mechanic. Capacity, loadout, drop rate, or quality bonuses.
X.1.1	Passive — Offense	L2	10 pts	Always-active offensive advantage. Requires X.1.
X.1.2	Passive — Defense	L2	10 pts	Always-active defensive advantage. Requires X.1.
X.1.1.1	Active — Offense	L3	15 pts	Player-triggered offensive skill. Cooldown defined per skill. Requires X.1.1.
X.1.1.2	Passive — Synergy	L3	15 pts	Always-active. Includes a thematic boost to Y tree's powerup root if any points are spent in Y. Requires X.1.1.
X.1.2.1	Active — Defense	L3	15 pts	Player-triggered defensive skill. Cooldown defined per skill. Requires X.1.2.
X.1.2.2	Passive — Soft Counter	L3	15 pts	Always-active. Weakens Z tree skills against this player. Requires X.1.2.
X.1.1.1.1	Powerful Active — Off	L4	20 pts	Aspirational. Strong player-triggered offensive skill. Requires X.1.1.1.

Position	Type	Level	Cost	Description
X.1.1.1.2	Powerful Passive — Off	L4	20 pts	Aspirational. Strong always-active offensive bonus. Requires X.1.1.1.
X.1.1.2.1	Synergy Active	L4	20 pts	Player-triggered. Extra bonus if Y tree has at least one L2 skill. Requires X.1.1.2.
X.1.1.2.2	Synergy Passive	L4	20 pts	Always-active. Extra bonus if Y tree has at least one L2 skill. Requires X.1.1.2.
X.1.2.1.1	Powerful Active — Def	L4	20 pts	Aspirational. Strong player-triggered defensive skill. Requires X.1.2.1.
X.1.2.1.2	Powerful Passive — Def	L4	20 pts	Aspirational. Strong always-active defensive bonus. Requires X.1.2.1.
X.1.2.2.1	Hard Counter Active	L4	20 pts	Player-triggered. Hard-counters a Z tree skill classification. Requires X.1.2.2.
X.1.2.2.2	Hard Counter Passive	L4	20 pts	Always-active. Hard-counters a Z tree skill classification. Requires X.1.2.2.

6.4 Active Skill Schema

Every active skill in the tree carries the following parameters in addition to its effect description:

Parameter	Type	Values / Description
cooldownType	Enum	per_match — fixed number of uses per match per_X_rounds — usable every X rounds charge_based — builds passively
cooldownValue	Integer	Number of uses per match, rounds between uses, or rounds to charge.
targetScope	Enum	round match tournament passive season
matchScope	Enum	match tournament — for cooldowns that span more than one match (e.g. Neural Scan).

phaseAffinity (from v0.2) is no longer in the schema. The v0.3 "one active skill per round" rule supersedes pre/post-info phase distinctions: an active skill can be used in either Phase 1 or Phase 2, but never both in the same round.

6.5 Skill Classification System

All skills belong to named classifications. Counter-skills block an entire classification, not individual skills. This makes the counter system clean and parametric.

Example classifications: Read, Influence, Luck, Pattern, Tie-Alteration, Counter-Read, Counter-Influence, Counter-Luck. The full classification list — and the tag assigned to each individual skill — is captured as a TBD (see Section 17, item 2).

Classification tags are how counter skills target their effects. Mind Shield, for example, blocks anything tagged Read; Oblivious blocks anything tagged Tie-Alteration. Until tags are finalized, individual node descriptions enumerate target skills explicitly.

6.6 Powerup Roots & Synergies — Summary Table

Quick-reference companion to the per-tree node tables in 6.7–6.9. Shows each tree's L1 base effect and L3 synergy enhancement.

Node	Tree Combo	Baseline Effect (X.1)	Synergy Enhancement (X.1.1.2)
MIND.1	MIND	5 powerup slots. Start season with 4 Basic + 1 Advanced.	If any MYSTIC points: swap to 3 Basic + 1 Advanced + 1 Legendary at season start.
MYSTIC.1	MYSTIC	+15% chance of one tier higher on random drops, +5% Legendary chance.	If any FORTUNE points: start season with 1 Legendary powerup.
FORTUNE.1	FORTUNE	2× powerup drop rate per round. Playtesting flag.	If any MIND points: gain a 6th powerup slot (starts each season empty).

Baseline Powerup Slots: All players start with 3 slots. MIND.1 increases this to 5. FORTUNE.1.1.2 synergy adds a 6th slot (empty at season start). Slot count is the only way to expand beyond 3.

6.7 MIND Tree — "Deduce it"

Theme: Cold analytical deduction. Counters FORTUNE. Synergizes with MYSTIC.

Node ID	Name	Type	Effect
MIND.1	Mind Power	Powerup Root (L1)	5 powerup slots. Start season with 4 Basic + 1 Advanced powerups.
MIND.1.1	Neural Pattern Recognition (NPR)	Passive Offense (L2)	Accumulates 10% chance per round to identify NPC's current throw logic at 90% accuracy. Resets to 0% at match start and after firing. On fire: independent flat 10% chance of false result (always applies, never scales). False result looks identical to correct read.
MIND.1.2	Blank Slate	Passive Defense (L2)	NPC pattern-reading strategies (Historian, Streaker, Mimic) treat your last 2 throws as unknown when calculating next move. Always active.

Node ID	Name	Type	Effect
MIND.1.1.1	Neural Scan	Active Offense (L3)	Triggered: identifies NPC throw logic at 90% accuracy. Cooldown: once every 5 matches. Player-only skill.
MIND.1.1.2	Desperate Clarity	Passive Synergy (L3)	If the player loses 2 consecutive rounds, +20% permanently added to current NPR accumulation total for remainder of match. One-time per match. Stacks with Advanced NPR. Synergy: if any MYSTIC points, swap season loadout to 3 Basic + 1 Advanced + 1 Legendary.
MIND.1.2.1	Memory Wipe	Active Defense (L3)	Purges throw history from NPC memory — NPC reverts to base strategy as if match just started. Cooldown: once per match. Player-only.
MIND.1.2.2	The Cooler	Passive Soft Counter (L3)	50% chance opponent TML/ATML fails and opponent loses round. Only activates when opponent uses TML/ATML. Upgrades to 75% when The Freezer purchased.
MIND.1.1.1.1	Neural Scan 2.0	Powerful Active (L4)	Replaces Neural Scan entirely. Same 90% accurate on-demand read of NPC throw logic. Cooldown reduced from once every 5 matches to once every 3 matches. One shared UI button and cooldown tracker with Neural Scan.
MIND.1.1.1.2	Adv. Neural Pattern Recognition	Powerful Passive (L4)	NPR per-round accumulation: 10% → 15%. Always active.
MIND.1.1.2.1	Mental Mysticism	Synergy Active (L4)	Precondition: hasNPRFiredThisMatch = true. 90% tie-to-win. Cooldown: every 3 rounds.
MIND.1.1.2.2	Uncanny Mind	Synergy Passive (L4)	+10% tier upgrade chance / +5% Legendary chance on random drops. Stacks additively with MYSTIC.1.
MIND.1.2.1.1	Total Recall	Powerful Active (L4)	Memory Wipe AND reveals base strategy NPC reverts to. Cooldown: once per match.
MIND.1.2.1.2	Clean Slate	Powerful Passive (L4)	After any purge: Historian/Streaker/Mimic locked out for 3 rounds.
MIND.1.2.2.1	Not Today!	Hard Counter Active (L4)	95% chance TML/ATML fails and opponent loses round. Cooldown: every 3 rounds. Takes precedence over Cooler/Freezer.

Node ID	Name	Type	Effect
MIND.1.2.2.2	The Freezer	Hard Counter Passive (L4)	Upgrades The Cooler: 50% → 75% block chance.

MIND Signature: Pattern Decryption. NPR reveals NPC's current behavioral strategy — never the switch trigger. Game is intentionally unsolvable. Players cannot collect enough data to fully predict any NPC.

Desperate Clarity (MIND.1.1.2): Lose 2 in a row → +20% NPR boost permanently for match. One-time. Must be two consecutive losses.

MIND.1.1.1.1 renamed from Total Recall to Neural Scan 2.0 in v0.7. Effect updated: replaces Neural Scan, same 90% accurate read, cooldown reduced from 5 matches to 3 matches. MIND.1.2.1.1 retains the name Total Recall.

6.8 MYSTIC Tree — "Bend it"

Theme: Supernatural reality alteration. Counters MIND. Synergizes with FORTUNE.

Node ID	Name	Type	Effect
MYSTIC.1	Mystical Power	Powerup Root (L1)	+15% chance of one tier higher on random drops. +5% Legendary chance. Stacks with Uncanny Mind.
MYSTIC.1.1	Tweak Reality	Passive Offense (L2)	30% chance natural tie converts to win. Upgrades to 60% with Alter Reality.
MYSTIC.1.2	Reverse Card	Passive Defense (L2)	25% chance any opponent active skill fires for MYSTIC player instead. Always active.
MYSTIC.1.1.1	Force Your Hand	Active Offense (L3)	90% tie-to-win. No effect on non-tie rounds. Cooldown: every 5 rounds.
MYSTIC.1.1.2	Third Time's the Charm	Passive Synergy (L3)	Tracks tie-conversion attempts across Tweak Reality, Alter Reality, Force Your Hand, Twist Your Arm. Two consecutive failures → next attempt boosted to 95%. Failure = tie occurred but was not converted (including blocked by Oblivious). Successful conversion resets counter. One-time per match. The boosted attempt is still subject to Oblivious/Totes Oblivious. Synergy: if any FORTUNE points, start season with 1 Legendary powerup.

Node ID	Name	Type	Effect
MYSTIC.1.2.1	Brain Fart	Active Defense (L3)	Nullify opponent active skill + add 2 rounds to cooldown. Cooldown: every 3 rounds.
MYSTIC.1.2.2	Mind Shield	Passive Soft Counter (L3)	50% block on NPR or Neural Scan. Upgrades to 90% with Mind Fortress.
MYSTIC.1.1.1.1	Twist Your Arm	Powerful Active (L4)	Replaces Force Your Hand. 90% tie-to-win. Cooldown: every 3 rounds. One cooldown tracker.
MYSTIC.1.1.1.2	Alter Reality	Powerful Passive (L4)	Upgrades Tweak Reality: 30% → 60%. Replaces value.
MYSTIC.1.1.2.1	Refuse to Lose	Synergy Active (L4)	90% loss → tie. Tie is immune to ALL tie-altering skills. Cooldown: every 3 rounds.
MYSTIC.1.1.2.2	Probability Storm	Synergy Passive (L4)	50% chance when earning non-Basic drop: receive 2 of that powerup instead of 1. Overflow prompt if slots full.
MYSTIC.1.2.1.1	Massive Brain Fart	Powerful Active (L4)	Nullify opponent active skill + add 3 rounds to its cooldown + add 1 round to all other opponent active skills. Cooldown: every 3 rounds.
MYSTIC.1.2.1.2	Bamboozle	Powerful Passive (L4)	25% chance any opponent powerup activates for MYSTIC player instead. Always active.
MYSTIC.1.2.2.1	Phantom Memory	Hard Counter Active (L4)	When Neural X skill fires against this player: plants false read. vs Player: random incorrect strategy. vs NPC: 100% false behavioral read. 1-round cooldown. Not triggered by IGaH.
MYSTIC.1.2.2.2	Mind Fortress	Hard Counter Passive (L4)	Replaces Mind Shield: 50% → 90% block chance.

MYSTIC Signature: Reality Alteration. Active takes precedence over passive. Refuse to Lose ties are immune to ALL tie-altering skills from either player. Alter Reality replaces Tweak Reality value. Twist Your Arm replaces Force Your Hand entirely.

Third Time's the Charm (MYSTIC.1.1.2): 2 consecutive failed tie conversions (any of 4 offensive tie-altering skills) → next attempt 95%. Blocked by Oblivious counts as failure. The boosted attempt is itself still subject to Oblivious/Totes Oblivious.

6.9 FORTUNE Tree — "Trust it"

Theme: Cosmic luck. Counters MYSTIC. Synergizes with MIND. Note: FORTUNE.1.1 is Active (L2) and FORTUNE.1.1.1 is Passive (L3) — intentional reversal.

Node ID	Name	Type	Effect
FORTUNE.1	Fortunate Power	Powerup Root (L1)	2× powerup drop rate per round. Playtesting flag — may need adjustment.
FORTUNE.1.1	Trust My Luck (TML)	Active Offense (L2)*	*Intentional reversal. Supersedes RPS choice. 75% auto-win / 25% auto-loss. Cooldown: every 5 rounds.
FORTUNE.1.2	Consolation Prize	Passive Defense (L2)	30% chance of earning a luck-themed Basic powerup when losing a round. Always active.
FORTUNE.1.1.1	Lucky Socks	Passive Offense (L3)*	*Intentional reversal. TML/ATML success: 75% → 85%. Upgrades to 95% with Fingers Crossed.
FORTUNE.1.1.2	Due for a Win	Passive Synergy (L3)	Tracks TML/ATML outcomes. Two consecutive failures → next attempt boosted to 95%. Successful outcome resets counter. One-time per match. Boosted attempt still subject to MIND counters. Synergy: if any MIND points, gain 6th powerup slot (starts each season empty).
FORTUNE.1.2.1	Change My Luck	Active Defense (L3)	If player loses this round: earn 2 luck-themed Basic+ powerups. If wins: fizzles. Cooldown: every 3 rounds.
FORTUNE.1.2.2	Oblivious	Passive Soft Counter (L3)	50% block any MYSTIC tie-altering skill (Tweak Reality, Force Your Hand, Twist Your Arm, Alter Reality). Upgrades to 90% with Totes Oblivious.
FORTUNE.1.1.1.1	Advanced TML (ATML)	Powerful Active (L4)	Replaces TML. Every 3 rounds (was 5). Success chance 85% (or 95% with Fingers Crossed). One cooldown tracker.
FORTUNE.1.1.1.2	Fingers Crossed	Powerful Passive (L4)	TML/ATML: 85% → 95%. Replaces Lucky Socks value.
FORTUNE.1.1.2.1	I've Got a Hunch (IGaH)	Synergy Active (L4)	50% chance of Neural Scan effect at 90% accuracy. Failure: silent fizzle. NOT subject to Mind Shield/Fortress/Phantom Memory. Cooldown: every 3 rounds.
FORTUNE.1.1.2.2	Make Your Own Luck	Synergy Passive (L4)	On any powerup drop: system generates 2 options, player chooses 1 via blocking UI prompt.

Node ID	Name	Type	Effect
FORTUNE.1.2.1.1	Reversal of Fortune	Powerful Active (L4)	Loss this round: earn 2 Advanced+ luck-themed powerups. Cooldown: every 3 rounds.
FORTUNE.1.2.1.2	Look What I Found	Powerful Passive (L4)	On loss: 25% independent chance of powerup one tier above Consolation Prize. Both can trigger on same loss.
FORTUNE.1.2.2.1	Lucky Charm	Hard Counter Active (L4)	MYSTIC tie-altering skill fires this round: reverses result to Lucky Charm player. Fizzles (consuming cooldown) if no tie-alteration fires. Fires after Oblivious fails to block. Cooldown: every 3 rounds.
FORTUNE.1.2.2.2	Totes Oblivious	Hard Counter Passive (L4)	Replaces Oblivious: 50% → 90% block chance.

FORTUNE Signature: Trust My Luck. TML/ATML supersede RPS choice. 75% → 85% (Lucky Socks) → 95% (Fingers Crossed). ATML replaces TML at every 3 rounds. MIND counters force failure branch.

Due for a Win (FORTUNE.1.1.2): 2 consecutive TML/ATML failures → next attempt 95% (once/match). Successful outcome resets counter. Boosted attempt still subject to MIND counter skills.

6.10 Respec Rules

- Full refund of all spent points at the start of each off-season.
- Player may completely reallocate across their two chosen trees.
- Mid-season: points can only be added (after each tournament award), not removed.
- Tree identity (which two trees chosen) cannot change for the life of the playthrough.
- Third tree remains hidden and inaccessible.
- NPCs do NOT receive off-season respecs — their trees grow by addition only.

7. Counter Interaction Matrix

Complete reference of all cross-tree counter interactions and their resolution rules.

Skill	Tree	Counters	Target Skills	Resolution
The Cooler	MIND	FORTUNE	TML, ATML	50% chance forces TML/ATML failure branch. Replaced by The Freezer (75%) when purchased.
Not Today!	MIND	FORTUNE	TML, ATML	95% chance forces TML/ATML failure. Active — takes precedence over Cooler/Freezer passive.
The Freezer	MIND	FORTUNE	TML, ATML	Replaces The Cooler — upgrades passive block to 75%.

Skill	Tree	Counters	Target Skills	Resolution
Mind Shield	MYSTIC	MIND	NPR, Neural Scan	50% block Neural X skill. Replaced by Mind Fortress (90%) when purchased.
Phantom Memory	MYSTIC	MIND	NPR, Neural Scan	After Neural X passes block: plants false strategy read. 1-round cooldown. Not triggered by IGaH.
Mind Fortress	MYSTIC	MIND	NPR, Neural Scan	Replaces Mind Shield — 90% block.
Oblivious	FORTUNE	MYSTIC	Tweak Reality, Force Your Hand, Twist Your Arm, Alter Reality	50% block — skill fizzles with flavor text. Replaced by Totes Oblivious (90%).
Lucky Charm	FORTUNE	MYSTIC	Tweak Reality, Force Your Hand, Twist Your Arm, Alter Reality	After Oblivious fails: reverses tie-altering result to Lucky Charm player. Fizzles if no tie-alteration fires.
Totes Oblivious	FORTUNE	MYSTIC	Tweak Reality, Force Your Hand, Twist Your Arm, Alter Reality	Replaces Oblivious — 90% block.

7.1 Resolution Order for Stacked Interactions

Scenario	Resolution Order
TML/ATML + MIND counter	1. Check Not Today! (95% fail) → 2. Check Cooler/Freezer (50%/75% fail) → 3. Resolve TML/ATML normally.
Neural X + Mind Shield	1. Roll Shield/Fortress block (50%/90%) → 2. If blocked: nullified → 3. Check Phantom Memory → 4. If fires: false read → 5. Otherwise: normal result.
Tie + multiple tie-altering skills	1. Immune tie check (Refuse to Lose) → 2. Active skill (90%) → 3. Passive roll (30%/60%) → 4. Oblivious/Totes block → 5. Lucky Charm reverse.
Consolation Prize + Look What I Found on loss	Both roll independently on same loss. Player may receive up to 2 powerups from a single lost round.

8. Powerup System

8.1 System Rules

Rule	Detail
Consumables	All powerups are consumable items with a real-world analog (food, potion, charm, artifact). Thematic to each tree.

Rule	Detail
Activation — Player	Always manually activated during Throw Selection or Gut Check phase.
Activation — NPC	Driven by NPC powerupStrategy field: asap on_loss on_win chance (50%). FIFO order within inventory.
Resolution Order	FIFO — first activated, first resolved.
Stacking	Multiples of same powerup allowed. No cap on simultaneous active effects.
Inventory	MIND: 5 slots (6 with Due for a Win synergy). Overflow: blocking UI prompt — replace or discard. No timeout, no default.
Tree Access	Tree-specific powerups only available to players with points in that tree. Cross-tree players draw from all pools equally.
Scope — Basic	Round or match scope only.
Scope — Advanced	Round, match, or tournament scope.
Scope — Legendary	Any scope. Season scope is rare.
Shorter = Stronger	Shorter scope = more powerful effect within tier.
Jessie Powerups	Player-only. NPCs cannot receive them.
No Skill References	Powerups never reference specific skill names. Effects are independent.
Autowin Per Tree	Each tree has exactly one round-scope Legendary autowin powerup.

8.2 Powerup Tiers

Tier	Visual Style	Typical Effect Magnitude
Basic	Simple pixel glow, standard icon (white tier glow).	Small advantage, possibly longer duration.
Advanced	Enhanced glow, animated pixel icon (blue tier glow).	Moderate advantage, balanced duration.
Legendary	Dramatic gold pixel treatment, screen flash on activation.	Major advantage, possibly game-changing.

Design Goal — Powerup Personality: Different players should value different powerup types based on their skill tree and playstyle. A FORTUNE/MIND player might prefer weaker effects with longer duration; a MYSTIC/FORTUNE player might favor short-burst legendary effects that synergize with their tie-conversion skills.

8.3 Slots & Starting Loadout

	Baseline	MIND.1	MYSTIC.1	FORTUNE.1	FORTUNE.1.1.2 (+MIND synergy)
Max Slots	3	5	3	3	6 (6th starts empty)
Season Start Loadout	1 Basic	4 Basic + 1 Advanced	Per drop upgrade boost	1 Basic	Unchanged — extra slot starts empty
Drop Rate Modifier	None	None	Upgrade chance boost (+15% / +5% Leg)	2× drop rate	None

MIND + MYSTIC synergy stacking: Uncanny Mind (MIND.1.1.2.2) and Mystical Power (MYSTIC.1) stack additively. Combined: up to +35% one-tier-higher chance, +10% Legendary chance on random drops.

8.4 Powerup Drop System

After winning a round (not losing or drawing), there is a chance to earn a powerup. Drop chances follow an escalating schedule per round within a match:

Round Won	Base Drop Chance	Overflow Behavior
Round 1	10%	N/A
Round 2	20%	N/A
Round 3	40%	N/A
Round 4	80%	N/A
Round 5	160%	Guaranteed 1 + 60% chance of second
Round 6	320%	Guaranteed 3 + 20% chance of fourth

Drop Overflow Rule: Drop chances can exceed 100%. The integer portion represents guaranteed powerups; the remainder is a chance for one additional powerup. Example: 250% = 2 guaranteed + 50% chance of a third. Distinct from inventory overflow (full slots), which is a separate UI prompt.

FORTUNE.1 multiplier (Fortunate Power) applies a 2× multiplier to these base chances per round. Playtesting flag — easy nerf to 1.5× if needed.

8.5 Upgrade Chance

On any powerup drop, there is a baseline 10% chance it upgrades one tier (Basic → Advanced, Advanced → Legendary). Legendary cannot upgrade further.

Upgrade Chance Modifiers: MYSTIC.1 (Mystical Power) adds +15% one-tier-higher chance / +5% Legendary chance. MIND.1.1.2.2 (Uncanny Mind) adds +10% one-tier-higher chance / +5% Legendary chance. Both stack additively (up to +35% / +10%).

8.6 Powerup Scope

Each powerup has a defined duration scope:

- Round — effect applies to one throw only.
- Match — effect persists for the remainder of the current match.
- Tournament — effect persists for the remainder of the current tournament.
- Season — effect persists for the remainder of the current season. Rare; mostly Legendary tier.

Scope availability by tier: Basic = round or match. Advanced = round, match, or tournament. Legendary = any scope, including the rare season scope.

8.7 Active Powerup UI

When a powerup is active, a persistent indicator is displayed on the match screen showing: powerup name, pixel art icon, tier visual (color-coded glow), and remaining duration (e.g. "2 rounds remaining", "active for this match"). The indicator clears automatically when the powerup expires. Displayed in SNES-style status bar.

8.8 Powerup Thematic Linking

Generated powerups are thematically linked to the player's two chosen trees. A FORTUNE/MIND player receives powerups with luck and reads themes. A MYSTIC/FORTUNE player receives powerups with influence and chaos themes. The Universal powerup (Changed My Mind) is available to all players regardless of tree. Tree-specific powerups are only available to players with at least one point in that tree.

8.9 Universal Powerup

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Changed My Mind	Basic	Round	Grants ability to change your throw during Gut Check. Available to all players regardless of tree.	Two arrows forming a circle

8.10 MIND Powerups

Basic

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Espresso Shot	Basic	Round	Play two throws this round — the better outcome counts.	Tiny espresso cup with steam
Focus Group	Basic	Match	Each round during Gut Check: "Most of the crowd seems to be on your side — and right now, it looks like they're throwing [X]." 65% accurate. Reflects NPC's initial throw. If NPC changes throw, tough luck.	Three tiny pixel people in a row

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Research Notes	Basic	Round	Reveals NPC's cumulative throw distribution across all matches this season. Historical only.	Folded document with corner turned down
Protein Shake	Basic	Round	Grants ability to change throw during Gut Check. If you change and win, earn 1 bonus Basic powerup drop.	Shaker bottle with lid

Advanced

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Focused Focus Group	Advanced	Match	Upgraded Focus Group — 80% accurate. Same mechanic.	Three tiny pixel people with magnifying glass overlay
A Word From Your Coach	Advanced	Match	Each round: one throw NPC is definitely NOT throwing is eliminated. Player may always change throw. [Monty Hall mechanic] Jessie powerup — player only.	Speech bubble with Jessie's pixel portrait
Dead Giveaway	Advanced	Round	Reveals NPC's initial throw with 100% accuracy. Player may change throw. NPC is aware and will attempt to change if capable.	Single nervous eye with sweat drop
Reading Glasses	Advanced	Tournament	15% chance per round of catching a tell. If triggered: "You notice a tell and think they will throw [X]." NPC unaware. Initial throw only.	Simple pair of glasses

Legendary

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
The Jessie Special	Legendary	Round	You win this round. Jessie saw something nobody else could see. No explanation given. Jessie powerup — player only.	Jessie's portrait with gold star
Jessie Did Her Homework	Legendary	Match	Pre-match: Jessie reveals NPC's current behavioral strategy. 99% accurate. Jessie powerup — player only.	Open book with Jessie's portrait
Courtside with Jessie	Legendary	Tournament	40% chance per round Jessie spots a tell. Jessie powerup — player only.	Jessie's portrait with whisper gesture

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Smart Glasses	Legendary	Season	20% chance per round of catching a tell all season. Always active.	Sleek futuristic glasses with glowing lenses

8.11 MYSTIC Powerups

Basic

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Mystic Pizza	Basic	Round	If you lose: round replays from Throw Selection. If you win or tie: fizzles.	Slice of pizza with mystical sparkle
Dizzy Spell	Basic	Round	NPC throws randomly this round AND cannot change their throw during Gut Check.	Swirl of stars (cartoon dizziness)
Schrödinger's Amulet	Basic	Round	If you change throw: both original and new throw exist — if either beats NPC, you win. Flag for playtesting.	Glowing amulet with two overlapping symbols
Hiccup Potion	Basic	Match	Every third round this match, NPC throws randomly regardless of strategy.	Small potion bottle with bubbles

Advanced

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Clockwork Orange	Advanced	Round	Reset all your active skill cooldowns to ready AND add 1 round to all opponent active skill cooldowns.	An orange with tiny clockwork gears inside
Tabula Rasa	Advanced	Match	NPC plays completely randomly for the entire match — no adaptation, no active skills, no powerups.	Blank stone tablet
Molasses	Advanced	Match	All opponent active skill cooldowns increased by 1 round — including any already cooling.	Small jar with thick dark liquid dripping
Padlock	Advanced	Tournament	Opponents cannot activate any powerups during the first 3 rounds of every match.	Closed padlock, slightly glowing

Legendary

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Fait Accompli	Legendary	Round	Activate before throw reveal. You win this round. Reality had no choice.	Sealed envelope marked DONE with a mystic seal
Cosmic Insurance Policy	Legendary	Match	Reset match to round 1. You remember everything. Opponent remembers nothing.	Rolled scroll with cosmic ribbon and stars
Cuckoo Clock	Legendary	Tournament	At the START of round 3 of every match this tournament: Clockwork Orange fires automatically.	Tiny pixel art cuckoo clock with door open
Jonesing to Help	Legendary	Season	At the start of every match this season, Jessie delivers 1 random Advanced powerup. Jessie powerup — player only.	Jessie's portrait with armful of powerup boxes

8.12 FORTUNE Powerups

Basic

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Fortune Cookie	Basic	Round	Change throw to a random selection. If you win, earn 2 Basic powerups.	Classic fortune cookie with tiny paper slip
Pandora's Box	Basic	Round	Both players throw randomly. If you win, all your active skill cooldowns reset to ready.	Small ornate box with light and chaos spilling out
Project Hail Mary	Basic	Round	Disables all your other powerups and active skills this round. Both players throw randomly. If you win, you win the match instantly.	Tiny rocket ship launching upward
Hot Sauce	Basic	Match	Every time you win 2 consecutive rounds this match, earn 1 Basic powerup.	Small hot sauce bottle with flames on label

Advanced

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Giant Fortune Cookie	Advanced	Round	Change throw to a random selection. If you win, earn 2 Advanced powerups.	Noticeably larger fortune cookie

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Ghost Pepper	Advanced	Tournament	Win 2 consecutive rounds = 1 Basic powerup. Win 3 consecutive = 1 Advanced powerup.	Small purple/black pepper with ghost wisp rising
Three's Company	Advanced	Match	If you win 3 consecutive rounds at any point this match, earn 3 Advanced powerups.	Three large pixel 3s side by side
Lucky Penny	Advanced	Match	Each round during Gut Check: call heads or tails. Correct call earns 1 Basic powerup. Independent of round outcome.	Shiny copper penny face-up glinting

Legendary

Name	Tier	Scope	Effect	Icon
Wish Upon a Star	Legendary	Round	You win this round. You wished for it. The universe complied.	Shooting star with trail of sparkles
Comically Large Fortune Cookie	Legendary	Round	Change throw to a random selection. If you win, earn 2 Legendary powerups.	Absurdly oversized fortune cookie
Carolina Reaper	Legendary	Tournament	Win 2 consecutive rounds = 1 Advanced powerup. Win 3 consecutive = 1 Legendary powerup.	Bright red pepper with angry face
The Ballad of Jessie Jones	Legendary	Season	All season: Win 2 consecutive = 1 Advanced. Win 3 consecutive = 1 Legendary. Jessie powerup — player only.	Jessie's portrait with musical notes, warm golden glow

9. Throw Distribution Statistics

9.1 Overview

The game tracks the player's Rock, Paper, and Scissors throw history across three scopes. This data serves two purposes: player curiosity (profile screen and post-match summary) and NPC strategy computation — Streaker, Historian, Mimic, and Counter all depend on throw history.

9.2 Tracking Scopes

Scope	Resets	Used By	Displayed
Round (current match)	Each new match	Streaker, Historian, Mimic, Counter — live during play	Match screen (optional subtle display)

Scope	Resets	Used By	Displayed
Season	Each off-season	Season stats panel; Research Notes powerup	Post-season summary, profile screen
Career	Never	Career stats, Hall of Fame context	Profile screen, career summary

9.3 Stats Tracked Per Scope

- Total throws of each type (Rock count, Paper count, Scissors count).
- Percentage distribution (e.g. Rock 42%, Paper 31%, Scissors 27%).
- Current streak — consecutive throws of the same sign (used by Streaker).
- Most frequently thrown sign overall (used by Mimic).
- Win rate per throw type (e.g. Rock wins 58% of the time for this player).

Data foundation: This section underpins the Streaker, Historian, Mimic, and Counter NPC strategies (Section 10.4) AND the Research Notes powerup (Section 8.10). Without this tracking, those features have no data source.

10. NPC System

10.1 Overview

The game maintains a roster of 99 NPC competitors (100 total players including the player) with real ELO ratings updated every season. Every match the player is not participating in is simulated, producing authentic season results and a living global ranking. NPCs earn skill points and powerups using the same rules as the player — they do NOT receive off-season respecs. Their trees grow by addition only each season.

NPC roster data is maintained in `npc_roster.json`. See that file for all 99 NPC definitions. The schema is defined in Section 10.2. An example NPC is shown in Appendix C.

10.2 NPC Profile Schema

Field	Type	Description
id	String	Unique identifier (e.g. npc_001).
name	String	Display name.
portraitId	String	Reference to portrait asset. Format: male_N or female_N (e.g. male_3, female_7), where N is 1–25. Pool: 25 male + 25 female portraits. Fully populated in v0.9 for all 99 NPCs. Cultural tone matched to NPC name origin. No same-portrait conflicts within any single tournament tier.
startingElo	Integer	ELO rating assigned at NPC creation — reflects intended difficulty tier. Used to reset ELO at start of new playthrough.
currentElo	Integer	Live ELO rating — updated after each tournament based on simulated match results.

Field	Type	Description
primaryTree	Enum	MIND MYSTIC FORTUNE.
secondaryTree	Enum null	MIND MYSTIC FORTUNE null. Must differ from primaryTree when set.
primaryStrategy	Enum	One of 13 strategies (see 10.4).
secondaryStrategy	Enum null	One of 13 strategies null. Must differ from primaryStrategy when set.
switchTrigger	Object null	{ condition, value } — null if no secondaryStrategy. See 10.5 for condition types.
tournamentLevel	Integer	1–5. Governs bracket eligibility and seeding.
powerupStrategy	Enum	asap on_loss on_win chance. Governs when NPC activates powerups. FIFO order within inventory. chance = 50% each round.
powerupInventory	Array	Cleared each season. Seeded by skill tree root node at season start. Grows via normal drop/reward system during season.
greeting	String	1–2 sentence flavor text shown before round 1 of a match. T1 NPCs may hint at strategy; T2+ greetings are personality-only with no strategic clues. All tiers: no rank references, championship status, or streak records.

ELO tuning intent: T1 ~820–1050, T2 ~960–1220, T3 ~1155–1420, T4 ~1360–1635, T5 ~1630–1950. Exact K-factor and values to be tuned during development. NPCs do NOT receive off-season respecs. Trees grow by addition only. Player advantage: full respec capability + one-time 15-point Season 1 starting bonus.

10.3 Tournament Level Distribution

Each NPC has a tournament level that restricts which tournaments they can appear in. Seeding within each tournament is still governed by ELO — but only from the eligible pool.

Level	Count (Actual)	Eligible Tournaments	Typical Complexity
T1 Local	10 NPCs	All tournaments	Single strategy (simple types only). No secondary strategy. Basic skill tree. Greetings may hint at strategy/personality.
T2 Regional	15 NPCs	Regional and above	Single strategy (moderate types). May or may not have secondary. Modest skill tree. Greetings personality-only.
T3 National	20 NPCs	National and above	May have secondary strategy. Moderate skill tree. Any powerup style. Greetings personality-only.

Level	Count (Actual)	Eligible Tournaments	Typical Complexity
T4 Continental	25 NPCs	Continental and above	Secondary strategy + trigger common. Deeper skill tree. Complex powerup behavior. Greetings personality-only.
T5 World	29 NPCs	World Championship only	Full configuration. Complex strategies (Historian, Streaker, Mimic). Deep cross-tree investment. Greetings personality-only.

Local NPCs Everywhere: The 10 T1 NPCs appear in every tournament. Players will encounter familiar faces repeatedly — a returning player recognizing "Benny Kowalski" and steamrolling them feels like satisfying progression. This is a deliberate gameplay/identity design decision, not just bracket-filling.

10.4 NPC Strategies

#	Strategy	Behavior Description
1	random	Pure random selection every round. No pattern.
2	puristRock	Always throws Rock. Set at NPC creation, never deviates.
3	puristPaper	Always throws Paper. Set at NPC creation, never deviates.
4	puristScissors	Always throws Scissors. Set at NPC creation, never deviates.
5	puristRandom	Picks one throw randomly at match start and throws it every round for that match. Re-rolls each new match (not season start).
6	mirror	Copies whatever the player threw in the previous round. First round is random.
7	counter	Throws whatever would beat the player's last throw. First round is random.
8	cycler	Rotates throws in a fixed sequence: Rock → Paper → Scissors → Rock.
9	momentum	Repeats their own winning throw until they lose a round, then picks randomly.
10	tilted	Plays normally until losing by 2 or more rounds, then switches to full random panic mode.
11	streaker	Observes player's throw sequence over 3+ rounds and attempts to counter detected patterns.
12	mimic	Tracks the player's most frequently thrown sign across the entire match and throws what beats it.
13	historian	Analyzes player's statistical throw distribution across the whole match/tournament. Counters the statistically most likely next throw. Improves in accuracy the longer the match runs.

MVP Strategy Set (v0.1): Only random, puristRock, puristPaper, puristScissors, puristRandom, and mirror are implemented in v0.1. Remaining strategies activate in v0.2 with the full NPC roster.

10.5 NPC Switch Trigger Conditions

Condition	Description	Example Value
losing_by	Switch when trailing by N rounds in the match.	1 or 2
winning_by	Switch when leading by N rounds in the match.	1 or 2
reach_round	Switch when match reaches round N.	3, 4, or 5
tournament_stage	Switch when tournament reaches a specific stage.	"quarterfinals" or "semifinals"

Switch trigger is null for any NPC with no secondaryStrategy. The two fields are always consistent: if secondaryStrategy is null, switchTrigger is null, and vice versa.

10.6 NPC Progression & Season Simulation

NPCs earn skill points and powerups using the same rules as the player. NPCs do NOT receive off-season respecs — trees grow by addition only each season. Season simulation: at end of each season, all NPC vs NPC matches across all 5 tournaments are simulated. Results update currentElo for all NPCs. Bracket display: NCAA tournament style — player's path only. NPC results populate bracket as tournament progresses. Player advantage: one-time 15-point Season 1 starting bonus. Player advantage: full off-season respec capability.

10.7 Player-Only Skills — NPC Behavioral Equivalents

Player Skill	NPC Equivalent Status
MIND.1.1 — Neural Pattern Recognition (NPR)	Passive. NPC throw prediction gains a +10% weight toward the correct counter to the player's most likely next throw, based on current match history. No explicit firing event. Always active.
MIND.1.1.1 — Neural Scan	Passive spike. Once every 5 matches, the NPC's strategy engine gains a one-round spike where the accuracy override chance jumps to 50%. No player notification. Silent.
MIND.1.1.1.1 — Neural Scan 2.0	Passive spike. Same as Neural Scan NPC equivalent but spike occurs every 3 matches instead of 5. One shared cooldown tracker with Neural Scan.
MIND.1.1.1.2 — Adv. Neural Pattern Recognition	Passive. NPR accuracy override increases from +10% to +15% per round. Replaces base NPR weight. Always active.
MIND.1.1.2 — Desperate Clarity	Passive. If NPC loses 2 consecutive rounds, +20% is permanently added to its current accuracy override for the remainder of the match. Once per match. Must be two consecutive losses.
MIND.1.1.2.1 — Mental Mysticism	Passive. Once the NPC has won at least one read-influenced round this match, gains a flat 15% tie-to-win chance for the remainder of the match. No cooldown. Condition checked each round.

Player Skill	NPC Equivalent Status
MIND.1.1.2.2 — Uncanny Mind	Identical to player version. +10% tier upgrade chance / +5% Legendary chance on random powerup drops. Stacks additively with MYSTIC.1 if NPC also has that node.
MIND.1.2 — Blank Slate	Passive. Any player read skill (NPR, Neural Scan, Neural Scan 2.0, IGaH) that fires against this NPC has its accuracy reduced by 5%. Stacks independently with Mind Shield/Fortress block chance and Phantom Memory false read. Always active.
MIND.1.2.1 — Memory Wipe	Active. When triggered: increases all player active skill cooldowns that are currently counting down by 1 round. Cooldown: once per match.
MIND.1.2.1.1 — Total Recall	Active. When triggered: increases all player active skill cooldowns that are currently counting down by 2 rounds. Cooldown: once per match.
MIND.1.2.1.2 — Clean Slate	Passive. When NPC activates Memory Wipe or Total Recall: 33% chance that skill's cooldown is immediately refreshed. If triggered, the refreshed skill cannot fire again until the next round (one active per round cap applies). Always active.
MIND.1.2.2 — The Cooler	Passive. 50% chance player's TML/ATML fails and player loses that round. Upgrades to 75% when The Freezer is purchased. Always active.
MIND.1.2.2.1 — Not Today!	Active. 95% chance player's TML/ATML fails and player loses that round. Cooldown: every 3 rounds. Takes precedence over Cooler/Freezer.
MIND.1.2.2.2 — The Freezer	Passive. Upgrades The Cooler: 50% → 75% block chance against player's TML/ATML. Always active.
IGaH (FORTUNE.1.1.2.1)	Passive spike. Once every 3 rounds, the NPC's strategy engine gains a one-round spike where the accuracy override chance jumps to 50%. Not subject to Phantom Memory, Mind Shield/Fortress, or Blank Slate's -5% penalty. Silent — no player notification.
All Jessie powerups	Player-only. NPCs cannot receive or use any Jessie-themed powerups.

11. ELO & Global Ranking System

11.1 Overview

A worldwide ranking of all 100 players (player + 99 NPCs) is maintained using an ELO-style rating system. Rankings update at the end of each season based on simulated and live results. This provides a season-to-season motivational meta-goal independent of tournament wins. The player competes within this pool of 100, earning their place rather than being added on top of it.

11.2 ELO Mechanics

- All 100 players have ELO ratings.
- Ratings update after each tournament based on wins, losses, and opponent rating.

- Standard ELO formula applies — beating a higher-rated opponent yields more points.
- Exact K-factor and starting ELO to be tuned during development.
- NPC starting ELO ranges by tier are defined in Section 10.2 (T1 ~820–1050 through T5 ~1630–1950).

11.3 Ranking Milestones & Celebrations

The game surfaces contextual celebratory messages when the player hits ranking milestones:

Milestone	Example Message
Enter rankings	"You've entered the world rankings!"
Top 50	"You've broken into the top 50!"
Top 20	"You broke into the top 20!"
Top 10	"You're in the top 10 in the world!"
Top 3	"You're one of the top 3 players on the planet!"
#1	"You are the #1 ranked RPS player in the world!"
New personal best	"You hit a new personal best ranking!"
First Championship	"First Championship! You've reached the pinnacle!"
3-Time Champion	"Three-Time World Champion!"

12. Hall of Fame

12.1 Eligibility

After the player's 10th season ends (regardless of result), Hall of Fame eligibility is evaluated. The player is inducted if they finished in the top 3 cumulative ELO rankings across all 10 seasons.

12.2 Cumulative Ranking

Each season, the player's end-of-season ELO ranking is recorded. After 10 seasons, their average or cumulative ranking score is calculated. Placement in the top 3 of this all-time ranking list triggers induction. Exact aggregation method (mean rank vs. weighted vs. cumulative ELO points) to be tuned during playtesting.

12.3 Induction

Hall of Fame induction is the culminating achievement of a playthrough. It is marked with a celebratory pixel art screen and a permanent HOF plaque added to the player's trophy case on their career summary screen. Coach Jessie appears with her most emotional dialogue sequence — a 4-box player-tap-dismissed sequence: (1) fistpump: "You did it." (2) determined: "When I walked into that gym and found you, I had one of those feelings. The kind you don't get very often. The kind that tells you something real is about to happen. I was right." (3) fistpump: "Hall of Fame. The youngest class in years. And you belong in there with every name on that wall." (4) whisper: "I'm proud of you. I want you to know that. Whatever comes next — I'm glad we got to do this together."

HOF status carries forward as Career Stats — visible on the profile screen as a permanent achievement. There is no HOF "unlock" of additional content; induction itself is the prize.

13. Trophy & Achievement System

13.1 Tournament Trophies

A milestone trophy is awarded after each tournament win. Trophies are visually distinct per tournament:

Tournament	Trophy Style
T1 Local Championship	Small bronze pixel art cup — animated sparkle on earn.
T2 Regional Championship	Silver regional trophy — slightly more elaborate pixel art.
T3 National Championship	Gold national trophy — animated gleam effect.
T4 Continental Championship	Gleaming continental trophy/belt — more frames of animation.
T5 World Championship	Grand world championship trophy — most elaborate pixel art, full celebration sequence.

Runner-up finishes may earn a silver variant of each trophy (TBD during art direction).

13.2 Trophy Case

The career summary screen displays a pixel art trophy case showing all earned trophies in full color (with subtle animation) and unearned trophies as dark silhouettes. The HOF plaque occupies a special position in the trophy case when earned.

14. UI/UX Specifications

14.1 Platform & Orientation

Platform	Orientation	Notes
Desktop (PC/Mac)	Any	Full layout, mouse input, larger pixel art scaled up.
Mobile (iOS/Android)	Portrait (primary)	Touch input, scrollable panels, large tap targets for R/P/S buttons.
Tablet	Portrait preferred	Scale up mobile layout.

14.2 Match Screen Elements

The following elements are visible during an active match:

- Season number and tournament name (SNES-style top status bar).
- Round name badge — pixel art badge (Sweet Sixteen, Elite Eight, Semifinals, Final).
- Player portrait + name (left, SNES portrait box style).

- Opponent portrait + name (right, SNES portrait box style).
- Round score — large pixel font, center.
- Round History Panel — see Section 5.3 for spec.
- Powerup inventory slots — visible, tappable before each phase.
- Active powerup indicator — name, pixel icon, tier glow, duration remaining.
- R/P/S buttons — large pixel art hand symbols, touch-friendly.
- Trust My Luck button — FORTUNE players only. Visual intensity scales with success chance.
- Active skill buttons — visible only when applicable; one active skill total per round.
- Ready button — advances Phase 2 Gut Check skill information panel.

14.3 Bracket UI

Tournament bracket displayed in NCAA basketball tournament style. Shows player's path through the bracket only (v0.1). NPC match results populate the bracket as the tournament progresses. Completed matches show winner name and score. Upcoming matches show seeds and NPC names.

Full bracket view (showing all NPC vs NPC matches) is a Post-v1.0 consideration. Through v1.0, only the player's path is rendered.

14.4 Skill Tree Screen

Displayed during mid-season point allocation and off-season respec:

- Only the player's two chosen trees are shown — third tree hidden entirely.
- Tree displayed as a visual node graph with pixel art connector lines.
- Locked nodes greyed out; unlocked but unpurchased nodes shown normally; purchased nodes highlighted.
- Tap/click any node to view: name, description, cost, type, classification, synergy/counter notes.
- Add Point button — spends one point on the selected node (prerequisites must be met).
- Remove Point button — refunds one point from selected node (off-season respec only; greyed out mid-season).
- Running counter: "X points remaining" always visible.
- Lock In button at bottom — confirms allocation and advances to next phase. Disabled until at least one node has been purchased. This applies both at pre-season (new season start) and at off-season respec. See Section 4.7 Minimum Spend rule and Section 16.13.

14.5 Career Summary / Profile Screen

Accessible from the main menu. Displays:

- Character name and pixel art portrait.
- Current ELO rating and world ranking (out of 100).
- Season record: seasons played, championships won, best finish per season.
- Throw distribution stats: career R/P/S percentages and win rates (see Section 9).
- Trophy case: pixel art display, earned vs silhouette.
- Hall of Fame plaque (if inducted).
- Career stats: total matches, win/loss ratio, longest season, best ELO achieved.

14.6 Post-Season Summary Screen

Shown at season end (both win and loss):

- Current tournament stats (rounds won, opponents defeated).
- Full season stats (tournaments entered, deepest finish).
- Career stats snapshot.
- ELO change for the season with milestone callout if applicable.

- Trophy reveal animation for any newly earned trophies.
- If non-finalist, non-championship season end: Jessie consolation dialogue + skill point award (see Section 4.6).
- Proceed to off-season respec.

15. Coach Character — Jessie "Jazz Hands" Jones

15.1 Overview

Jessie "Jazz Hands" Jones is a retired Hall of Fame World Champion who serves as the player's coach and mentor. She sees promise in the player and offers warm, encouraging guidance through the game's mechanics. Her coaching is the in-world explanation for the player's starting skill point advantage and consolation bonuses (see Section 4.4). Her presence is light-touch and never intrusive.

Attribute	Details
Full Name	Jessie "Jazz Hands" Jones
Role	Retired Hall of Fame World Champion. Player's coach, mentor, and in-narrative source of competitive advantage.
Narrative	Flesh-and-blood human analyst — not magical, not lucky. She sees promise in the player and takes them under her wing.
Tone	Warm, encouraging, slightly quirky, never condescending. Light and cute presence.
Appearance	Unique pixel art portrait. Female. Distinct from player/NPC portrait pool. Displayed in classic SNES RPG dialog box — Chrono Trigger NPC style.
Toggle	On/Off in settings. Defaults ON for new players.
Scope	Full tutorial coverage of all major mechanics + occasional milestone moments throughout career.

15.2 Tutorial Coverage

Jessie guides players through the following mechanics (in approximate order of encounter):

- Round flow — blind selection, skill phase, confirmation, the two-phase model.
- Active skills — how to trigger, the one-active-skill-per-round rule, cooldown indicators.
- Powerup system — activation, tiers, slot management, FIFO order, scope durations.
- Skill tree — spending points, offense vs defense, synergy nodes, prerequisite rule.
- Bracket navigation — reading tournament progress.
- ELO and rankings — why rankings matter across seasons.
- Off-season respec — encouraging the player to try new builds.
- Trust My Luck — when and why to use it (FORTUNE players).

15.3 Milestone Dialogue

Jessie makes brief appearances at key milestone moments even after the tutorial is complete:

Beat ID	Moment — Trigger, Type, Expression
M-01	First tournament win — post-T1-Final win, pre-trophy reveal. One-shot. fistpump.
M-02	First Finals appearance — post-semifinal win (any tournament, first time). One-shot. determined.
M-03	New ELO milestone — ranking enters top 50 for first time. One-shot. fistpump.
M-04	World Championship runner-up — post-T5-Final loss. Repeatable (once per runner-up finish). determined.
M-05	Hall of Fame induction — HOF eligibility confirmed, Season 10. One-shot. 4-box sequence (fistpump / determined / fistpump / whisper).
M-06	First World Championship win — post-T5-Final win. Repeatable (once per World Championship win). 4-box sequence (fistpump / determined / whisper / fistpump).
M-07	Career end, no HOF — HOF eligibility fails after Season 10. One-shot. determined.
M-08	First comeback win — player wins match from 0-2 down, first time. One-shot. fistpump.
M-09	Perfect match — player wins 3-0 or 4-0, first time. One-shot. fistpump.
M-10	First Legendary powerup — first Legendary acquired. One-shot. whisper.
M-11	First TML success — FORTUNE players only, TML fires successfully, first time. One-shot. facepalm. Auto-dismiss ~3s.
M-12	Season check-in — start of Seasons 3-10. Rotating pool of 8 lines. Once per season.

Jessie naming palette for powerups (see Appendix B.2): "A Word From Your Coach", "Jonesing to Help", "The Ballad of Jessie Jones", "The Jessie Special", "Jessie Did Her Homework", "Courtside with Jessie". Flavor principle: Jessie is skeptical of mystical/luck elements but shows up anyway because she believes in you.

15.4 Tutorial Beats — Full Specification

Each tutorial beat fires exactly once per career and covers one mechanic at the moment of first encounter. T-10 (inventory full) was retired as it is covered by UI. T-11 (separate active skill beat) was merged into T-08 (unified). Full dialogue and trigger details are in SRPS_Tutorial_Flow_DRAFT_v3.docx (locked as of 2026-04-27).

ID	Name	Trigger	Type	Expression
T-01	Meet Jessie	Post-character-creation, pre-tree-selection	14-box sequence (narration + portrait)	Multiple — see full spec
T-02	Tree Selection	Season 1 tree selection screen opens	Single-box, blocking	determined

ID	Name	Trigger	Type	Expression
T-03	Skill Point Allocation	Skill tree screen opens with 15 pts	Single-box, blocking	whisper
T-04	Bracket Navigation	First bracket screen opens	Single-box, blocking	default
T-05	Blind Selection	Phase 1, Round 1, Match 1 (first ever Phase 1)	Single-box, blocking	determined
T-06	Gut Check	First ever Phase 2 entry	Single-box, blocking	whisper
T-07	Resolution + Round History	First ever round resolution	Auto-dismiss ~3s	fistpump (win) / determined (loss) / default (tie)
T-08	Active Skill Button	First round any active skill is ready (all trees)	Single-box, blocking	whisper
T-09	Powerup Earned	First powerup acquisition (MIND: pre-M1R1; others: first in-match drop)	Single-box, blocking	fistpump
T-12	ELO & Rankings	First global ranking screen shown	Single-box, blocking	default
T-13	Off-Season Respec	Off-season respec screen opens (end of Season 1)	Single-box, blocking	determined
T-14	Second Tree Unlock	Season 2 tree selection screen opens	Single-box, blocking	fistpump

T-01 is the only multi-box beat and the only beat that contains narration boxes (no portrait). Boxes 1-4, 10, and 12 are narration; all others are Jessie portrait boxes. [X] in Box 13 is substituted at runtime from STARTING_SKILL_POINTS_SEASON_1 constant. [Unlock] and [Done] in T-03 are UI label placeholders. [Skill Name] in T-08 is substituted at runtime with the player's active skill name.

15.5 Milestone Beats — Full Specification

Milestone beats fire at emotionally significant moments across the full 10-season career. One-shot beats are tracked in `_trophies.jessieOneShots`. M-04 and M-06 are repeatable and are never added to `jessieOneShots`. M-12 uses a separate pool manager (`jessieSeasonCheckInHistory`). Full dialogue is in `SRPS_Additional_Jessie_Dialogue_v2.docx` (locked as of 2026-04-27).

ID	Moment	Trigger	Type	Expression
M-01	First Tournament Win	Win T1 Local Final, pre-trophy reveal	Single-box, one-shot	fistpump

ID	Moment	Trigger	Type	Expression
M-02	First Finals Appearance	Win any semifinal, first time ever	Single-box, one-shot	determined
M-03	New ELO Milestone	Ranking enters top 50, first time	Single-box, one-shot	fistpump
M-04	World Championship Runner-Up	Lose T5 World Final	Single-box, repeatable	determined
M-05	Hall of Fame Induction	HOF eligibility confirmed, Season 10	4-box sequence, one-shot	fistpump/determined/fistpump/whisper
M-06	World Championship Win	Win T5 World Final	4-box sequence, repeatable	fistpump/determined/whisper/fistpump
M-07	Career End, No HOF	HOF fails after Season 10	Single-box, one-shot	determined
M-08	First Comeback Win	Win match from 0-2 down, first time	Single-box, one-shot	fistpump
M-09	Perfect Match	Win 3-0 or 4-0, first time	Single-box, one-shot	fistpump
M-10	First Legendary Powerup	Acquire first Legendary powerup	Single-box, one-shot	whisper
M-11	First TML Success	TML fires successfully, first time (FORTUNE only)	Auto-dismiss ~3s, one-shot	facepalm
M-12	Season Check-In	Start of each season, S3-S10	Single-box, pool of 8	Varies (see pool table)

M-12 pool: 8 lines, one per season S3-S10, no repeats within a career where possible. Pool resets if all 8 exhausted. Line 5 uses expression “angry” in the sense of competitive fire, not displeasure. M-05 and M-06 are 4-box sequences; all others are single-box.

16. Coding Gotchas & Implementation Notes

16.1 NPR System

Two distinct reset triggers: match start AND post-fire within same match. Two independent RNG rolls on fire: (1) does it fire this round? (2) is result false? False result chance: always flat 10% — never

scales, never reaches 0%. Advanced NPR modifies accumulation rate only — not accuracy or false result chance. Track as running total: 10% round 1, 20% round 2, etc. Resets to 0% on fire or match start. Desperate Clarity boost: adds +20% to current total permanently for match remainder — does not reset on NPR fire.

16.2 Neural Scan Cooldown

Cooldown is per-match (once every 5 matches) — needs match counter not round counter. Entirely separate from NPR's round-based accumulation.

16.3 Mental Mysticism Precondition

Boolean flag `hasNPRFiredThisMatch` must persist across rounds, reset at match start. Separate from NPR accumulation state — two distinct trackers. Button only appears when `hasNPRFiredThisMatch = true`.

16.4 Blank Slate / Memory Wipe

NPC strategy engines (Historian, Streaker, Mimic) need a `maskedThrows` parameter. Blank Slate: always mask last 2 throws from those strategies. Memory Wipe: reset NPC strategy to base — reference NPC schema for base strategy. Clean Slate lockout: round counter decrements each round — 3 rounds, then strategies resume.

16.5 TML/ATML System

Lucky Socks and Fingers Crossed are sequential — Fingers Crossed replaces value, never stacks. ATML replaces TML entirely — one cooldown tracker, one UI button. TML/ATML: insert one check before rolling — "is a MIND counter skill active this round?" Failure branch = auto-loss. Due for a Win: track consecutive TML/ATML failures separately. Boolean resets on success. One-time 95% boost per match.

16.6 Tie Resolution System

Immune tie flag (`tielsImmune = true`) set by Refuse to Lose — blocks ALL tie-altering skills. Flag cleared at round end. Active skill check before passive roll — if active triggered, passive does not roll. Alter Reality replaces Tweak Reality value (60% not 30% + 60%). Third Time's the Charm: track consecutive failed conversions — reset on success, one-time 95% boost. Blocked by Oblivious counts as failure. Lucky Charm consumes cooldown even when fizzling on no-tie round.

16.7 Phantom Memory

Fires after Neural X passes Mind Shield block check — before result displayed to player. When fires: overrides normal result with false (incorrect) strategy read. 1-round cooldown. Not triggered by IGaH. NPC using Phantom Memory vs player: 100% false behavioral read — random strategy shown.

16.8 Inventory & Powerup Prompts

Probability Storm fires before overflow check — generate both powerups first, then check slots. Make Your Own Luck: blocking UI prompt for choice, may be immediately followed by overflow prompt. All blocking UI prompts are mandatory — no timeout, no default. Overflow: blocking UI prompt — replace or discard. Game cannot proceed until player chooses.

16.9 Replacement vs Stacking Rules

Skill Pair	Rule
The Cooler (50%) + The Freezer (75%)	The Freezer replaces The Cooler value.
Lucky Socks (85%) + Fingers Crossed (95%)	Fingers Crossed replaces Lucky Socks value.
Tweak Reality (30%) + Alter Reality (60%)	Alter Reality replaces Tweak Reality value.
Force Your Hand + Twist Your Arm	Twist Your Arm replaces Force Your Hand — one button, one cooldown.
TML + ATML	ATML replaces TML entirely — one button, one cooldown.
Mind Shield (50%) + Mind Fortress (90%)	Mind Fortress replaces Mind Shield value.
Oblivious (50%) + Totes Oblivious (90%)	Totes Oblivious replaces Oblivious value.
MYSTIC.1 + MIND.1.1.2.2 upgrade chances	Stack additively: up to +35% tier upgrade, up to +10% Legendary chance.

16.10 Powerup Implementation Notes

Resolution: FIFO. Focus Group: 65% accurate. Focused Focus Group: 80%. Both reflect NPC initial throw only. Schrödinger's Amulet: fails if NPC throws the one option beating BOTH original and new throw. Flag for playtesting. Project Hail Mary: no interference from any skills or powerups. Both throws purely random. Fait Accompli: activates pre-throw. Lucky Penny: 50/50 coin flip. Independent of round outcome. Dead Giveaway: NPC is aware and will attempt throw change if capable. Cuckoo Clock: Clockwork Orange fires at START of round 3 of every match — not every 3 rounds. Jonesing to Help: overflow rules apply — blocking prompt before match begins. The Ballad of Jessie Jones: streak tracking resets each match. Win 2 = Advanced. Win 3 = Legendary.

16.11 Purist Strategy Variants

puristRock, puristPaper, puristScissors: NPC always throws that sign. Set at NPC creation, never changes. puristRandom: NPC picks one throw randomly at match start and throws it every round for the duration of that match. Re-rolls at the start of each new match (NOT at season start).

16.12 Skill Classification Tags

Implementation note: Assign a classificationTag enum to every skill so counter-skills can target by category rather than hardcoding individual skill names. The skill tree is fully locked, so this is a code-hygiene concern rather than a design concern. Suggested tag set: Read, Influence, Luck, Pattern, Tie-Alteration, Counter-Read, Counter-Influence, Counter-Luck. Full tag assignment pass to be done at implementation time, not in this design document. Counter-skill target lists in Section 7 are authoritative for design purposes.

16.13 Lock In Gate — Minimum Spend Enforcement

The Lock In button on the skill tree screen must be disabled until at least one node is purchased. This applies in two contexts: (1) pre-season allocation (new season start, after tree selection); (2) off-season respec (after full point refund). The gate condition is: `Object.values(treeState).some(tree => Object.values(tree).some(v => v === true))`. Do not check point balance — check purchased node count directly. Rationale: without this gate, a player can proceed with no nodes purchased, leaving the starting powerup loadout in an undefined state (no root node means no loadout seeded). The root node is always the cheapest legal node (5 pts) and is always affordable — the gate is a UX guard, never an impossible condition.

16.14 Jessie One-Shot Gate

Before firing any one-shot Jessie beat (T-01 through T-14, M-01 through M-12 excluding M-04 and M-06): check `_trophies.jessieOneShots.includes(beatId)`. If true, skip the beat entirely. After firing: push `beatId` to `jessieOneShots` and call `saveTrophies()` immediately — do not wait for end of match or season. M-04 (World Championship Runner-Up) and M-06 (World Championship Win) are repeatable — never gate them, never add them to `jessieOneShots`. When Jessie toggle is OFF: do NOT record beat IDs. Beats will fire when Jessie is re-enabled. M-12 uses a separate pool tracker (`jessieSeasonCheckInHistory`) — see Section 15.5 and CLAUDE.md Section 9.4 for pool manager implementation.

17. TBDs and Outstanding Decisions

17.1 Skill Tree TBDs

#	Item	Notes
1	Player-only skill indicator — UI	Visual treatment for player-only vs NPC-shared skills. Icon or label TBD.
2	Skill classification tags	Reclassified in v0.8 — not a design-doc concern. The skill tree is fully locked; counter skills already enumerate targets explicitly in Section 7. Classification tags are an implementation detail. See Section 16 coding note for implementation guidance. No design-doc TBD action required.

17.2 NPC System TBDs

#	Item	Notes
3	NPC behavioral equivalents for player-only skills	COMPLETE in v0.7. All MIND tree and IGaH NPC equivalents defined in Section 10.7.
4	Neural X / Phantom Memory NPC interaction	COMPLETE in v0.7. See Section 10.7 — NPR, Neural Scan, Neural Scan 2.0 NPC equivalents fully defined.
5	IGaH NPC interaction	COMPLETE in v0.7. NPC IGaH equivalent: passive spike, 50% accuracy override every 3 rounds, not subject to Phantom Memory/Mind Shield/Blank Slate.
6	Skill point bonus intervals	COMPLETE in v0.9. No additional bonus intervals needed — the three existing mechanisms (Season 1 starting points, tournament winner/runner-up awards, and consolation bonus) fully cover the skill point economy. Season 1 starting points clarified as one-time only.
7	Greeting cleanup pass — T2 and T3	COMPLETE in v0.8. 18 T2 and T3 greetings updated to remove strategy hints, streak records, and observation cues. All T2/T3 greetings now personality-only. See npc_roster.json.
8	portraitId population	COMPLETE in v0.9. All 99 NPCs assigned a portraitId in npc_roster.json. Format: male_N or female_N (pool of 25 male + 25 female portraits). Cultural tone matched to NPC name origin. No same-portrait conflicts within any tournament tier. 48 of 50 portraits used; max reuse of any portrait is 5x across different tiers.

17.3 Powerup System TBDs

#	Item	Notes
9	Consolation bonus — full option set	COMPLETE in v0.8. Fixed skill point award per tournament level (T1: 25 pts, T2: 20 pts, T3: 15 pts, T4: 10 pts, T5: 5 pts). Triggered by pre-finals elimination only. Jessie dialogue locked. See Section 4.6.
10	Schrödinger's Amulet balance	Flag for playtesting — may be too powerful for Basic tier.
11	Espresso Shot balance	Flag for playtesting — two throws, better counts. May be too powerful for Basic.
12	FORTUNE.1 (Fortunate Power) 2× rate	Flag for playtesting — may be too generous. Easy nerf to 1.5× if needed.

17.4 UI / Content TBDs

#	Item	Notes
13	Flavor text — full content pass	Every counter interaction needs flavor text. Pattern: "[Name] tried to [Skill] but [Name2] was [Counter]". Full pass across all 3 trees.

#	Item	Notes
14	Coach Jessie — complete dialogue set	COMPLETE in v1.0. Tutorial beats T-01 through T-14 specified in SRPS_Tutorial_Flow_DRAFT_v3.docx. Milestone beats M-01 through M-12 specified in SRPS_Additional_Jessie_Dialogue_v2.docx. Sections 15.4 and 15.5 added to design doc. All dialogue locked.
15	Portrait assets — final pixel art	Player and NPC: 50 pixel art portraits (25 male, 25 female) complete. Jessie: 8 expression variants complete. Placeholder set for v0.1; final pixel art pass for v1.0.
16	Powerup icon final pixel art	All 37 icons described. Final pixel art pass needed at ~24×24px.
17	Runner-up trophy variants	Silver-variant trophies for runner-up finishes — TBD during art direction.

17.5 Architecture TBDs

#	Item	Notes
18	CLAUDE.md generation	Generate in new Claude chat against completed v1.0 design doc.
19	Skill tree engine test harness	Unit tests for every skill interaction type before wiring into live game.
20	NPC simulation performance	99 NPCs across 5 tournaments must be async. Benchmark with console.time().
21	localStorage schema migration	Schema designed upfront. Migration function needed when schema changes.
22	Backend migration (v1.0 stretch)	localStorage → server backend for cross-device accounts.
23	ELO K-factor and starting value	To be tuned during development.

18. MVP Scope & Version Roadmap

Note: Version numbers in this section (v0.1 through v1.0) refer to game release milestones — playable builds released during development. These are independent from the design document version numbers tracked in the Version Control table at the start of this document.

18.1 Version Overview

Version	Name	Focus
v0.1	MVP	Core playable loop — one tournament, basic mechanics, no skill trees
v0.2	Core Progression	All 5 tournaments, full season structure, ELO simulation

Version	Name	Focus
v0.3	Skill Trees	Skill trees (levels 1–2), off-season respec, NPC tree configs
v1.0	Complete Game	Full 4-level trees, all powerups, Hall of Fame, complete NPC roster

18.2 v0.1 — MVP

The minimum viable product establishes the core game loop and validates the fundamental mechanics.

- Account system: login/password, 1 character per account, localStorage persistence.
- Character creation: name + portrait selection (scrollable gallery of all 50 portraits).
- Tournament 1 only: Local Championship (2-round bracket, 4 players).
- Core round loop: all 4 phases functional (powerup activation placeholder, skill phase placeholder).
- NPC strategies: random, puristRock, puristPaper, puristScissors, puristRandom, mirror.
- Basic bracket UI: player's path, result population.
- Basic ELO tracking: player ELO updates after tournament.
- Post-tournament summary screen (basic).
- SNES visual style: pixel fonts, portrait boxes, chunky UI panels.
- Intro narration screen with text-crawl reveal.
- Mobile portrait layout, touch input.
- No skill trees, no powerups, no off-season in v0.1.

18.3 v0.2 — Core Progression

- All 5 tournaments with correct bracket sizes and round counts.
- Full season structure: advancement rules, season end conditions.
- Off-season screen (placeholder respec — no trees yet).
- Full NPC roster: all 99 NPCs defined, all 13 strategies implemented.
- Full ELO simulation: all NPC vs. NPC matches simulated each season.
- Global ranking display with milestone celebrations.
- Career summary screen with basic stats and throw distribution.
- Post-season summary screen with consolation bonus (Jessie dialogue + skill point award for pre-finals eliminations).
- Trophy system: 5 trophy types, trophy case on career screen.
- Powerup system: drop mechanics only, Basic tier, no tree-specific powerups.

18.4 v0.3 — Skill Trees

- All 3 trees implemented, levels 1–2 only.
- Active skill system: one-active-skill-per-round rule, cooldowns, UI buttons.
- Skill point allocation UI: node graph, tap to inspect, Add/Remove/Lock In.
- Mid-season point spending after each tournament (add-only).
- Full off-season respec.
- Season 1 / Season 2 tree selection rules enforced.
- NPC tree configs active: NPCs spend points per their tree preferences.
- 3 characters per account.
- Trust My Luck button for FORTUNE tree players (levels 1–2 effect, 75% baseline).
- Cross-tree synergy nodes (level 3 — may slide to v1.0).

18.5 v1.0 — Complete Game

- Full 4-level skill trees with all 15 nodes per tree defined and implemented.

- All cross-tree synergy pairs active.
- All counter skill classifications implemented.
- Complete powerup catalog: Basic, Advanced, Legendary tiers with full thematic variety.
- Hall of Fame: 10-season evaluation, induction screen, HOF plaque.
- Full NPC roster with complex strategy + skill tree + powerup behaviors.
- Trust My Luck fully implemented across all FORTUNE levels (75% / 85% / 95%).
- Skill information phase fully implemented with NPC skill interactions.
- Full portrait set: final illustrated assets replacing SVG placeholders.
- Coach Jessie: complete tutorial coverage of all major mechanics + full dialogue set for all milestone moments.
- Difficulty levels: groundwork laid (player advantage tuning).
- v1.0 stretch: backend migration for cross-device account persistence.

18.6 Future Considerations (Post-v1.0)

- Audio: 8-bit chiptune background music and sound effects.
- Full bracket view: all NPC matches visible, not just player's path.
- Difficulty levels: formalized easy/normal/hard settings.
- Additional NPC strategies beyond the initial 13.
- Achievement system beyond Hall of Fame.
- Cross-device account sync (backend migration).

Appendix A — Skill Tree Quick Reference

MIND Tree

Node	Name	Type	Effect Summary
MIND.1	Mind Power	Root	5 slots. Start: 4 Basic + 1 Advanced.
MIND.1.1	Neural Pattern Recognition	Pass. Offense L2	+10%/round → 90% read. Flat 10% false result always.
MIND.1.2	Blank Slate	Pass. Defense L2	Last 2 throws masked from NPC pattern strategies.
MIND.1.1.1	Neural Scan	Active L3	On-demand 90% read. 5-match cooldown. Player-only.
MIND.1.1.2	Desperate Clarity	Pass. Synergy L3	Lose 2 in a row → +20% NPR (once/match). Synergy: 3B+1A+1L start.
MIND.1.2.1	Memory Wipe	Active L3	Reset NPC to base strategy. Once/match. Player-only.
MIND.1.2.2	The Cooler	Pass. Soft Counter L3	50% block TML/ATML → auto-loss.
MIND.1.1.1.1	Neural Scan 2.0	Powerful Active L4	Replaces Neural Scan. 90% accurate read. Cooldown: every 3 matches (was 5).
MIND.1.1.1.2	Adv. NPR	Powerful Passive L4	NPR accumulation 10% → 15%/round.

Node	Name	Type	Effect Summary
MIND.1.1.2.1	Mental Mysticism	Synergy Active L4	90% tie-to-win if NPR fired this match. Every 3 rounds.
MIND.1.1.2.2	Uncanny Mind	Synergy Passive L4	+10% tier upgrade / +5% Legendary on drops.
MIND.1.2.1.1	Total Recall	Powerful Active L4	Memory Wipe + free strategy read. Once/match.
MIND.1.2.1.2	Clean Slate	Powerful Passive L4	Post-purge: NPC pattern strategies locked 3 rounds.
MIND.1.2.2.1	Not Today!	Hard Counter Active L4	95% block TML/ATML → auto-loss. Every 3 rounds.
MIND.1.2.2.2	The Freezer	Hard Counter Passive L4	Upgrades The Cooler: 50% → 75%.

MYSTIC Tree

Node	Name	Type	Effect Summary
MYSTIC.1	Mystical Power	Root	+15% tier upgrade / +5% Legendary on drops.
MYSTIC.1.1	Tweak Reality	Pass. Offense L2	30% tie → win. Upgrades to 60% with Alter Reality.
MYSTIC.1.2	Reverse Card	Pass. Defense L2	25% chance opponent active skill fires for you.
MYSTIC.1.1.1	Force Your Hand	Active L3	90% tie → win. Every 5 rounds.
MYSTIC.1.1.2	Third Time's the Charm	Pass. Synergy L3	2 consecutive failed conversions → 95% next (once/match). Synergy: +1 Legendary at season start.
MYSTIC.1.2.1	Brain Fart	Active L3	Nullify opponent active + 2 rounds cooldown. Every 3 rounds.
MYSTIC.1.2.2	Mind Shield	Pass. Soft Counter L3	50% block NPR/Neural Scan. Upgrades to 90% with Mind Fortress.
MYSTIC.1.1.1.1	Twist Your Arm	Powerful Active L4	Replaces Force Your Hand. Every 3 rounds.
MYSTIC.1.1.1.2	Alter Reality	Powerful Passive L4	Tweak Reality: 30% → 60%.
MYSTIC.1.1.2.1	Refuse to Lose	Synergy Active L4	90% loss → immune tie. Every 3 rounds.
MYSTIC.1.1.2.2	Probability Storm	Synergy Passive L4	50% chance non-Basic drop yields 2 powerups.

Node	Name	Type	Effect Summary
MYSTIC.1.2.1.1	Massive Brain Fart	Powerful Active L4	Nullify + 3 rounds its cooldown + 1 round all others. Every 3 rounds.
MYSTIC.1.2.1.2	Bamboozle	Powerful Passive L4	25% chance opponent powerup activates for you.
MYSTIC.1.2.2.1	Phantom Memory	Hard Counter Active L4	Neural X fires → plant false read. 1-round cooldown.
MYSTIC.1.2.2.2	Mind Fortress	Hard Counter Passive L4	Upgrades Mind Shield: 50% → 90%.

FORTUNE Tree

Node	Name	Type	Effect Summary
FORTUNE.1	Fortunate Power	Root	2× powerup drop rate. Playtesting flag.
FORTUNE.1.1	Trust My Luck (TML)	Active L2*	*Intentional reversal. 75% auto-win / 25% auto-loss. Every 5 rounds.
FORTUNE.1.2	Consolation Prize	Pass. Defense L2	30% chance Basic luck powerup on round loss.
FORTUNE.1.1.1	Lucky Socks	Pass. L3*	*Intentional reversal. TML/ATML: 75% → 85%.
FORTUNE.1.1.2	Due for a Win	Pass. Synergy L3	2 consecutive TML/ATML fails → 95% next (once/match). Synergy: 6th powerup slot.
FORTUNE.1.2.1	Change My Luck	Active L3	Loss → earn 2 Basic+ luck powerups. Every 3 rounds.
FORTUNE.1.2.2	Oblivious	Pass. Soft Counter L3	50% block MYSTIC tie-altering skills. Upgrades to 90% with Totes Oblivious.
FORTUNE.1.1.1.1	Advanced TML (ATML)	Powerful Active L4	Replaces TML. Every 3 rounds.
FORTUNE.1.1.1.2	Fingers Crossed	Powerful Passive L4	TML/ATML: 85% → 95%.
FORTUNE.1.1.2.1	I've Got a Hunch (IGaH)	Synergy Active L4	50% chance 90% strategy read. Not blocked by MYSTIC counters. Every 3 rounds.
FORTUNE.1.1.2.2	Make Your Own Luck	Synergy Passive L4	Powerup drops: choose from 2 options.
FORTUNE.1.2.1.1	Reversal of Fortune	Powerful Active L4	Loss → 2 Advanced+ luck powerups. Every 3 rounds.

Node	Name	Type	Effect Summary
FORTUNE.1.2.1.2	Look What I Found	Powerful Passive L4	25% on loss: powerup one tier above Consolation Prize. Stacks with CP.
FORTUNE.1.2.2.1	Lucky Charm	Hard Counter Active L4	MYSTIC tie-alter fires → reverse to your favor. Every 3 rounds.
FORTUNE.1.2.2.2	Totes Oblivious	Hard Counter Passive L4	Upgrades Oblivious: 50% → 90%.

Appendix B — Session Context & Design Decisions

Key decisions and context preserved for continuity across chat sessions.

B.1 Synergy Passive Design Framework

All three synergy passives share a thematic through-line: two consecutive failures trigger a one-time boost per match. Desperate Clarity (MIND.1.1.2): Lose 2 rounds in a row → +20% NPR accumulation permanently for match remainder. Third Time's the Charm (MYSTIC.1.1.2): 2 consecutive failed tie conversions → next attempt 95%. Blocked by Oblivious counts as failure. Due for a Win (FORTUNE.1.1.2): 2 consecutive TML/ATML failures → next attempt 95%. Still subject to MIND counters. All: one-time per match. Successful outcome resets consecutive counter. Must be two in a row.

B.2 Jessie Jones Design Guidelines

Coach Jessie Jones is a flesh-and-blood human analyst — not magical, not lucky. Appears most in MIND tree (most thematically aligned). One Jessie appearance each in MYSTIC and FORTUNE Legendary. Jessie powerups are player-only — NPCs cannot receive them. Jessie naming palette: "A Word From Your Coach", "Jonesing to Help", "The Ballad of Jessie Jones", "The Jessie Special", "Jessie Did Her Homework", "Courtside with Jessie". Flavor principle: Jessie is skeptical of mystical/luck elements but shows up anyway because she believes in you.

B.3 Powerup Design Principles

Every powerup has a real-world consumable analog (food, potion, charm, artifact). No references to specific skill names in powerup effects. Shorter scope = more powerful effect within tier. Every tree has exactly one round-scope Legendary autowin. Icons: pixel art ~24×24px. Final art pass TBD.

B.4 Thematic Powerup Families

HOT SAUCE FAMILY: Hot Sauce (Basic, Match) → Ghost Pepper (Advanced, Tournament) → Carolina Reaper (Legendary, Tournament) → The Ballad of Jessie Jones (Legendary, Season, Jessie powerup). FORTUNE COOKIE FAMILY: Fortune Cookie (Basic) → Giant Fortune Cookie (Advanced) → Comically Large Fortune Cookie (Legendary). READING GLASSES FAMILY: Reading Glasses (Advanced, Tournament, 15%) → Smart Glasses (Legendary, Season, 20%) → Courtside with Jessie (Legendary, Tournament, 40%, Jessie powerup).

B.5 Numeric Values Locked

Item	Value
Focus Group accuracy	65%
Focused Focus Group accuracy	80%
MYSTIC.1 tier upgrade bonus	+15% one tier higher, +5% Legendary
MIND.1.1.2.2 (Uncanny Mind) bonus	+10% one tier higher, +5% Legendary
Stacked upgrade bonus (both active)	Up to +35% tier upgrade, up to +10% Legendary
FORTUNE.1 drop rate multiplier	2× (playtesting flag — easy nerf to 1.5×)
Reading Glasses accuracy	15% per round (tournament)
Smart Glasses accuracy	20% per round (season)
Courtside with Jessie accuracy	40% per round (tournament)
Jessie Did Her Homework accuracy	99%

B.6 NPC Design Decisions

NPC greeting rule: T1 greetings may hint at strategy/personality. T2+ greetings are personality-only — no clues about tree, strategy, or switch behavior. All tiers (including T1): no rank references, no championship status, no streak records, no win/loss tallies. These statements become false within seasons and break immersion. Personality traits (confident, intimidating, philosophical, friendly, trash-talking) are always fair game. Secondary tree must always differ from primary tree. Secondary strategy must always differ from primary strategy. puristRandom: re-rolls at match start each match (not season start). powerupStrategy is per-NPC (not per-powerup): asap | on_loss | on_win | chance (50% hardcoded). FIFO inventory order always applies.

B.7 Session Conventions

Document versioning rule: Each new chat session is constrained to modifying a single document version. Do not increment the version number mid-session — produce one output version per chat. The current canonical design document is v0.8. Always upload both the latest design doc and npc_roster.json at the start of each new session as context anchors. Two independent versioning schemes coexist: design document versions (v0.1 → v0.8, tracking doc revisions) and game release milestones (v0.1 MVP → v1.0 Complete Game, defined in Section 18). These should never be confused. NPC roster data lives in npc_roster.json — the design doc references it. The yellow-background note block style (cornsilk italic) is reserved for gotchas, implementation notes, and rules callouts.

B.8 Gap Recovery Pass (v0.6.1 session)

This session was a gap-recovery pass: comparing v0.1, v0.2, and v0.3 against v0.6 to identify content that fell out of the doc as it evolved. Restored items include Core Design Pillars, Technology Stack, the

full Visual Style section, Account & Character System, Jessie's Competitive Advantage, the Skill Resolution Hierarchy, Information Reliability, structural framing for the skill tree (overview, naming convention, type reference, active skill schema, classification system, root+synergy summary), the mid-season add-only respec rule, the entire structural side of the Powerup System (tiers, slots, drops, upgrade chance, scope, UI, thematic linking), Throw Distribution Statistics, Tournament Level Distribution + Local NPCs Everywhere, the ELO & Global Ranking System, Hall of Fame, Trophy & Achievement, UI/UX Specifications, the Coach Jessie character spec and milestone dialogue, the Terminology Appendix, and minor MVP roadmap items. Sections renumbered as a result. No locked decisions were altered.

B.9 Superseded Mechanics Reference

Mechanics from earlier doc versions that have been deliberately replaced. Listed here so future sessions don't accidentally re-introduce them:

Old (deprecated)	New (current)	Replaced In
Working title "RPS Champion"	"Superhuman Rock Paper Scissors" (SRPS)	v0.2
INSTINCT tree	MIND tree	v0.2
6-phase round flow	4-phase round flow (Throw Selection / Gut Check / Countdown / Resolution)	v0.3
phaseAffinity (pre / post / both) on active skills	One-active-skill-per-round rule (skill can fire in either phase)	v0.3
TML success by tree level (60/70/80/90%)	Node-based progression: 75% (TML) → 85% (+Lucky Socks) → 95% (+Fingers Crossed)	v0.3
Reality Fracture (defense branch)	Reality Alteration mechanics (offense branch); Refuse to Lose covers loss-to-tie	v0.3
5 NPC powerup behavior styles (Spender/Hoarder/Random/Clutch/Dominant)	powerupStrategy enum: asap on_loss on_win chance	v0.5
Single "purist" strategy (sign set at NPC creation)	Four variants: puristRock / puristPaper / puristScissors / puristRandom	v0.5
signatureMechanic field on NPCs	greeting field on NPCs	v0.5
powerupTriggers field on NPCs	powerupStrategy field (single enum value)	v0.5
100 NPCs + 1 player = 101 total	99 NPCs + 1 player = 100 total	v0.5
10 NPC strategies	13 NPC strategies (purist split into 4 variants)	v0.5

B.10 NPC Roster Notes

The current roster (npc_roster.json, meta.totalNpcs = 99) splits as T1 = 10, T2 = 15, T3 = 20, T4 = 25, T5 = 29. This actual distribution differs from the v0.2 plan (10/20/25/25/20%) — the doc reflects actual counts. Greeting cleanup is now fully complete across all tiers: T1 greetings may hint at strategy (by design); T2 and T3 greetings updated in v0.8 (18 greetings fixed: npc_011, 012, 013, 014, 016, 019, 023, 025, 026, 029, 031, 032, 034, 035, 036, 038, 039, 043); T4 and T5 were already clean. All tiers: no rank references, no championship status, no streak records. portraitId fully populated in v0.9 — all 99 NPCs assigned from a pool of 25 male + 25 female portraits (format: male_N / female_N). Cultural tone matched to NPC name origin; no same-portrait conflicts within any single tournament tier.

B.11 Known Ambiguities Carried Forward

(1) MIND.1.1.1.1 renamed from Total Recall to Neural Scan 2.0 in v0.7. Effect updated: replaces Neural Scan with a 3-match cooldown (reduced from 5). MIND.1.2.1.1 retains the name Total Recall. The naming collision is resolved. (2) The doc references "NCAA basketball tournament style" bracket UI in Sections 14.3 and 10.6 — visual reference is clear but the seeding algorithm (especially how Local NPCs appear in every tournament alongside ELO-seeded brackets) needs implementation detail. (3) Hall of Fame cumulative ranking calculation method (mean rank vs. weighted vs. cumulative ELO) is left to playtesting tuning.

B.12 Next Session Agenda

COMPLETED THIS SESSION (v0.95): localStorage schema fully defined and documented (9 key buckets, NPC initialisation algorithm, season-end simulation write order, in-memory-only state reference). Section 8.3.1 added — starting powerup loadout for all tree combinations. MYSTIC.1 conflict resolved. Minimum spend mandate locked. NPC starting budgets locked. NPC vs NPC simulation locked (ELO-probability only). NPC skill spending locked (random-from-legal-nodes, season end only). CLAUDE.md generated — 14 sections covering project identity, file map, tech stack, named constants (full constants.js starter), critical game system rules, localStorage rules, NPC rules, screen flow, version scope, what-ever-to-do, session protocol, testing approach, and design doc section index. DECISIONS.md generated — all locked decisions from all sessions, dated and versioned. TODO.md generated — full v0.1 MVP task list, broken down to implementable units, with v0.2/v0.3/v1.0 backlog. SRPS_ClaudeCode_Guidance.docx reviewed and updated. PRIORITY FOR NEXT SESSION: Coach Jessie dialogue set — tutorial coverage (Section 15.2) and milestone moments (Section 15.3). Design doc is otherwise Claude Code-ready.

Appendix C — Example NPC (Full Schema)

A single fully-worked T5 NPC demonstrating all schema fields. Reference for implementation. Mirrors npc_099 in npc_roster.json.

```
{ "id": "npc_099", "name": "Vera Ashmore", "startingElo": 1950, "currentElo": 1950,
  "primaryTree": "MYSTIC", "secondaryTree": "FORTUNE", "primaryStrategy": "mimic",
  "secondaryStrategy": "historian", "switchTrigger": { "condition": "tournament_stage", "value":
    "semifinals" }, "tournamentLevel": 5, "powerupStrategy": "on_win", "powerupInventory": [],
  "greeting": "I worked my entire life to be able to compete at this level. You will not find me easy to
    beat." }
```

Appendix D — Terminology

Term	Definition
SRPS	Superhuman Rock Paper Scissors — the game's full title.
RPS	Rock Paper Scissors — the core game mechanic.
Season	A full competitive year of up to 5 sequential tournaments.
Tournament	A bracket-style competition (Local through World Championship).
Match	A single head-to-head competition within a tournament (best of 5 or 7 rounds).
Round	A single throw of RPS within a match.
Finals	The championship match of any tournament (last 2 players).
Off-Season	The period between seasons for skill tree respec and preparation.
ELO	Rating system used to rank all 100 players (player + 99 NPCs).
MIND	The deduction/reads skill tree. Counters FORTUNE; synergizes with MYSTIC.
MYSTIC	The supernatural/reality-bending skill tree. Counters MIND; synergizes with FORTUNE.
FORTUNE	The luck/chaos skill tree. Counters MYSTIC; synergizes with MIND.
Node	An individual skill within a tree (15 per tree, 4 levels).
Active Skill	A skill requiring player activation. Has cooldown parameters. Limited to one per round.
Passive Skill	A skill that is always active once purchased. No activation required.
Powerup	One-time consumable advantage item (Basic / Advanced / Legendary).
Respec	Full refund and reallocation of all skill points during off-season.
Trust My Luck (TML)	FORTUNE-exclusive active skill: Fortune-powered auto-throw with a chance of automatic win.
ATML	Advanced Trust My Luck — Powerful Active L4 upgrade replacing TML.
Consolation Bonus	Fixed skill point bonus awarded by Jessie when a season ends with the player eliminated before reaching the finals of any tournament. Amount scales by how early the season ended (T1: 25 pts through T5: 5 pts). Delivered before the off-season respec. Players only — NPCs never receive it.
Hall of Fame	End-of-playthrough achievement for top 3 cumulative ranking after 10 seasons.
Pattern Decryption	MIND signature mechanic: probabilistically reveals NPC's current behavioral strategy.
Reality Alteration	MYSTIC signature mechanic: tie-conversion and loss-to-tie skills.

Term	Definition
Tournament Level	NPC attribute (1–5, Local/Regional/National/Continental/World) governing eligibility.
Synergy Node	X.1.1.2 — passive node giving cross-tree boost to partner tree's powerup mechanic.
Hard Counter	X.1.2.2.1 / X.1.2.2.2 — nullifies a full skill classification from the opposing tree.
Soft Counter	X.1.2.2 — passively weakens (but does not nullify) opposing tree skills.
NPC	Non-player character competitor (99 in the roster).
Classification	The category tag on a skill used by counter-skills to block effects.
Cross-Tree Synergy	Paired node interactions across the two chosen trees that produce oversized combined bonuses.
Jessie	Coach Jessie "Jazz Hands" Jones — Hall of Fame legend, player's mentor and competitive advantage.
Round History Panel	Persistent right-edge UI panel showing throw history for both player and opponent during a match.
Local NPCs Everywhere	Design rule: T1 NPCs appear in every tournament for player familiarity and progression feel.